

Hopf Bifurcations and Bistability in the Hodgkin-Huxley Equations at the 1952 Parameters: Computer-Assisted Proofs

Chase Hendrick

Independent Researcher

chasewhendrick@gmail.com

ORCID 0009-0002-9754-6087

Abstract

The space-clamped Hodgkin–Huxley equations with Hodgkin and Huxley’s constants are the standard model of the action potential, and their bifurcations are known from numerical computation. We prove several of them with computer assistance in ball arithmetic, for every leak reversal potential E_l in $[10.59, 10.62]$ mV, an interval that contains the value 10.613 printed by Hodgkin and Huxley and the value $E_l^* = 10.5989209693916 \dots$ that makes the resting current zero, as their Table 3 says it should. For every applied current J in $[0, 200]$ $\mu\text{A}/\text{cm}^2$ there is exactly one equilibrium. It is asymptotically stable except for J between two Hopf points, where it has exactly two eigenvalues with positive real part, and no eigenvalue lies on the imaginary axis at any other current in that range. At $E_l = 10.613$ the Hopf points lie at $J_{H1} \in [9.775437995393, 9.775437995394]$ and $J_{H2} \in [154.522433665808, 154.522433665809]$, and both move by exactly $0.3(10.613 - E_l)$ when E_l changes. The eigenvalues cross the imaginary axis transversally, and the first Lyapunov coefficient is positive at J_{H1} and negative at J_{H2} : the lower Hopf bifurcation is subcritical and the upper one supercritical. At $J = 8$, for every E_l in the interval, a locally asymptotically stable equilibrium coexists with an orbitally asymptotically stable periodic orbit, a train of action potentials with period between 16.0058 and 16.0140 ms: the model is bistable there. At three values of E_l we also enclose a periodic orbit of saddle type. The proofs combine a Routh–Hurwitz analysis along the branch of equilibria with a C^1 Lohner-type Taylor integrator, the Krawczyk test and a contraction argument on Poincaré sections. Nothing is claimed about the basins of attraction or about other attractors.

Keywords: Hodgkin–Huxley equations; Hopf bifurcation; first Lyapunov coefficient; bistability; periodic orbit; computer-assisted proof; ball arithmetic.

MSC 2020: 92C20, 34C23, 37G15, 37C27, 65G20.

1 Introduction

Hodgkin and Huxley’s equations for the squid giant axon [17] are the prototype of a conductance-based neuron model. With the membrane potential uniform in space (the space clamp), they form a system of four ordinary differential equations in the depolarization u and three gating variables m , n , h , with an applied current J as the natural parameter. The picture of their dynamics that textbooks and later models rely on is numerical: a single equilibrium, stable for small and large currents and unstable in between; a Hopf bifurcation at each end of the unstable range, subcritical at the lower end near $J \approx 9.78 \mu\text{A}/\text{cm}^2$; and, below that current, a range in which the resting state coexists with repetitive firing, so that a brief pulse can start or stop a train of action potentials. The coexistence was found in simulations by Cooley, Dodge and Cohen and observed in the squid axon by Guttman, Lewis and Rinzel [14], as reviewed by Lu, Xin and Rinzel [24, pp. 61–62]; Best

[2] showed numerically that a suitable brief pulse stops the firing for good. This paper proves parts of that picture at Hodgkin and Huxley’s own constants.

What is known. The bifurcations of the space-clamped equations have been computed numerically many times; we cite only what we have read, and how far. Troy proved a Hopf bifurcation for a modified system in which n and h are slowed by a small parameter, under assumptions that he describes as “made on the basis of numerical evidence” [30], and large-amplitude periodic solutions for a reduced system of three equations under assumptions [29]; his earlier paper [28] proves Hopf bifurcation “under appropriate assumptions” (abstract). None of these is a proof for the full system at the 1952 constants. Hastings writes that the parameters “appear, on the basis of numerical calculations, to be such that the system . . . has a unique equilibrium point” [16, p. 230]. Guckenheimer and Labouriau state that their bifurcation diagrams in the plane of the current and the potassium reversal potential “are conjectured on the basis of symbolic calculations, numerical computations and visual examination of a large number of phase portraits” [11, pp. 937–938]; Guckenheimer and Worfolk write about the same diagrams that “these diagrams have not been proved to be correct” [13, Sect. 5]. Fukai, Doi, Nomura and Sato computed the bistable periodic solutions in several parameters [8, 9]. Guckenheimer and Oliva continued the periodic orbits born at the subcritical Hopf point and found chaotic dynamics near $J = 7.86$, adding that “we do not give a rigorous proof that chaos exists in this system” [12, p. 106]. The numerical Hopf computations of Hassard [15] and the stable and unstable periodic solutions of Rinzel and Miller [26] we know only from these citing papers. Du and Hassard [7] computed Hopf bifurcation coefficients in interval arithmetic and applied the method to the Hodgkin–Huxley model; its first page says that “it is known with mathematical certainty that the exact values fall in the computed intervals”. We have read only that page and a review of the paper, so we do not know which Hopf points and parameters it covers, and we claim no priority for rigorous enclosures of the Hopf points or of their first Lyapunov coefficients. Computer-assisted proofs exist for the travelling pulse and for periodic orbits of the FitzHugh–Nagumo equations [1, 5], and for Hopf bubbles and degenerate Hopf bifurcations [4]; validated continuation of Hopf bifurcations is a general method [3].

This paper. We prove, for every leak reversal potential $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$:

- Theorem 1: for every $J \in [0, 200]$ there is exactly one equilibrium.
- Theorem 2: along this branch the equilibrium is asymptotically stable except between two currents $J_{H1} < J_{H2}$, where it has exactly two eigenvalues in $\text{Re } \lambda > 0$; at J_{Hi} it has a simple pair $\pm i\omega_i$ that crosses the imaginary axis transversally, and the first Lyapunov coefficient ℓ_1 is positive at J_{H1} and negative at J_{H2} . The currents are enclosed to 10^{-12} .
- Corollary 3: the Hopf bifurcation at J_{H1} is subcritical and the one at J_{H2} supercritical, in the sense of the normal form.
- Theorem 4: at $J = 8$ there is an orbitally asymptotically stable periodic orbit, a spike train with period in $[16.005827509, 16.013912063]$ ms.
- Theorem 5: at $J = 8$ and $E_l = 10.613$, E_l^* and 10.599 , a stable and a saddle-type periodic orbit, with narrow enclosures of their periods and Floquet multipliers.
- Corollary 6: bistability of rest and repetitive firing at $J = 8$, equivalently for $E_l = 10.613$ and every $J \in [7.9931, 8.0021]$.

We have not found an earlier proof that the space-clamped Hodgkin–Huxley equations at the 1952 constants have a unique equilibrium for all currents of a range, that their equilibrium has no other imaginary-axis crossings than the two Hopf points on such a range, that they have a stable periodic orbit, or that they are bistable. These statements are limited by the searches behind them, which are recorded in the project’s research ledger (entries of 2026-09-25 to 2026-09-27) and summarized in Section 10; some relevant papers could not be read in full, and they are listed there.

Labels. Every result carries one label. *Proved*: a written proof in this paper, with no computation. *Computer-assisted*: a written proof in which finitely many inequalities are decided by a program in ball arithmetic (Section 7); the program and the lines of its output that carry each step are named. *Cited*: a published theorem used as stated in its source, with its hypotheses checked here. *Numerical*: floating-point or high-precision computation without error control; numerical results are never used in a proof and are collected in Section 8. Paths such as `code/certlib.py` name files of the folder that accompanies this paper. Section 9 says how to rerun everything, and Section 10 lists what is not proved and which checks of this work have been made.

2 The model

2.1 The equations

We use the modern sign convention: $u = -V$ is the depolarization from rest in mV, where V is the displacement of Hodgkin and Huxley, and $J = -I$ is the applied depolarizing current in $\mu\text{A}/\text{cm}^2$; time is in ms and the temperature is 6.3°C , so no temperature factor enters. With the rate constants of [17, eqs. (12), (13), (20), (21), (23), (24)], the current equation [17, eq. (26)] and the constants of [17, Table 3] (the membrane capacity is $1 \mu\text{F}/\text{cm}^2$), the space-clamped equations read

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{u} &= J - I(u, m, n, h), & I &= g_{\text{Na}} m^3 h (u - E_{\text{Na}}) + g_{\text{K}} n^4 (u - E_{\text{K}}) + g_{\text{l}} (u - E_{\text{l}}), \\ \dot{y} &= \alpha_y(u)(1 - y) - \beta_y(u)y, & y &\in \{m, n, h\}, \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

with $g_{\text{Na}} = 120$, $g_{\text{K}} = 36$, $g_{\text{l}} = 0.3$, $E_{\text{Na}} = 115$, $E_{\text{K}} = -12$ and

$$\begin{aligned} \alpha_m &= \Psi\left(\frac{25-u}{10}\right), & \beta_m &= 4e^{-u/18}, & \alpha_n &= 0.1 \Psi\left(\frac{10-u}{10}\right), & \beta_n &= 0.125 e^{-u/80}, \\ \alpha_h &= 0.07 e^{-u/20}, & \beta_h &= \frac{1}{e^{(30-u)/10} + 1}, & \Psi(x) &= \frac{x}{e^x - 1}, & \Psi(0) &= 1. \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

We write $x = (u, m, n, h)$, $f(x; J, E_{\text{l}})$ for the right-hand side of (1), $k_y = \alpha_y + \beta_y$ and $y_{\infty} = \alpha_y/k_y$. Table 3 of [17] prints the leak potential $V_{\text{l}} = -10.613$ mV, that is $E_{\text{l}} = 10.613$, with the footnote “Exact value chosen to make the total ionic current zero at the resting potential ($V = 0$)”.

Lemma 2.1 (proved). (a) $\Psi(x) > 0$ and $\Psi'(x) < 0$ for every real x , so the six rates are positive and $y_{\infty}(u) \in (0, 1)$ for every $u \in \mathbb{R}$. (b) n_{∞} is strictly increasing on $\mathbb{R}$. (c) f is real-analytic on $\mathbb{R}^4 \times \mathbb{R}^2$ (in x , J and E_{l}). (d) The equilibria of (1) are exactly the points $x^*(u) = (u, m_{\infty}(u), n_{\infty}(u), h_{\infty}(u))$ with $J_{\text{ss}}(u) = J$, where $J_{\text{ss}}(u) = I(x^*(u))$ is the steady-state current.

Proof. (a) x and $e^x - 1$ have the same sign, so $\Psi > 0$. $\Psi'(x) = g(x)/(e^x - 1)^2$ with $g(x) = e^x - 1 - xe^x$ for $x \neq 0$; $g(0) = 0$ and $g'(x) = -xe^x$, so $g < 0$ for $x \neq 0$, and $\Psi'(0) = -1/2$ from the series $\Psi(x) = 1 - x/2 + \dots$. The other rates are exponentials or reciprocals of $e^{(30-u)/10} + 1 > 1$. (b) $n_{\infty} = 1/(1 + \beta_n/\alpha_n)$; β_n decreases in u , and α_n increases because Ψ decreases and $(10 - u)/10$ decreases. (c) Ψ is analytic on the strip $|\text{Im } x| < 2\pi$ (its only singularities are at $x = 2\pi ik$, $k \neq 0$,

since the zero at $x = 0$ of $e^x - 1$ is removable), $1/(e^{(30-u)/10} + 1)$ is analytic near the real axis, and f is polynomial in m, n, h, J, E_l . (d) $\dot{y} = 0$ means $y = \alpha_y/k_y$ since $k_y > 0$; then $\dot{u} = 0$ means $J = J_{ss}(u)$. $\square$

2.2 The leak potential

Lemma 2.2 (proved). $f(x; J, E_l) = f(x; J + g_l(E_l - E'), E')$ for all x, J, E_l, E' . Hence a statement about the system at (J, E_l) is a statement about the system at $(J + 0.3(E_l - E'), E')$. In particular every bifurcation current $J_*(E_l)$ satisfies $J_*(E_l) = J_*(10.613) + 0.3(10.613 - E_l)$, and the system at $J = 8$ with $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$ is the system at $E_l = 10.613$ with $J \in [7.9931, 8.0021]$.

Proof. E_l enters f only through $J + g_l E_l$ in $\dot{u} = (J + g_l E_l) - g_{Na} m^3 h(u - E_{Na}) - g_K n^4(u - E_K) - g_l u$. The last sentence is $8 + 0.3(E_l - 10.613) \in [8 - 0.0069, 8 + 0.0021]$. $\square$

Proposition 2.3 (computer-assisted). *The value of E_l for which the ionic current vanishes at the resting potential $u = 0$, that is $I(x^*(0)) = 0$, is*

$$E_l^* = \frac{-g_{Na} E_{Na} m_\infty(0)^3 h_\infty(0) - g_K E_K n_\infty(0)^4}{g_l},$$

and $E_l^* \in [10.5989209693916785221988785, 10.5989209693916785221988786]$. With $E_l = 10.613$ the ionic current at $u = 0$ is $0.3(E_l^* - 10.613) \in [-0.004223709183, -0.004223709182] \mu A/cm^2$, not zero.

The value 10.599 used by Fukai et al. [8, p. 216], who list it among the parameter values used by Hodgkin and Huxley, and by Guckenheimer and Oliva [12] agrees with E_l^* to the digits given. We have not found the difference between E_l^* and the printed 10.613 discussed in what we read, but our search for it was not exhaustive (Section 10); nothing in this paper depends on it. Because the qualitative statements below hold on the whole interval $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$, which contains 10.613, E_l^* and 10.599, the choice between these values does not matter for them, and Lemma 2.2 converts every current from one value to another.

2.3 The Jacobian at an equilibrium

Lemma 2.4 (proved). *At an equilibrium $x^*(u)$ the Jacobian of f is the arrow matrix*

$$A(u) = \begin{pmatrix} a_{11} & a_{1m} & a_{1n} & a_{1h} \\ a_{m1} & -k_m & 0 & 0 \\ a_{n1} & 0 & -k_n & 0 \\ a_{h1} & 0 & 0 & -k_h \end{pmatrix},$$

with $a_{11} = -(g_{Na} m^3 h + g_K n^4 + g_l)$, $a_{1m} = -3g_{Na} m^2 h(u - E_{Na})$, $a_{1n} = -4g_K n^3(u - E_K)$, $a_{1h} = -g_{Na} m^3(u - E_{Na})$ and $a_{y1} = \alpha'_y(1 - y) - \beta'_y y = k_y y'_\infty(u)$, everything at $x^*(u)$. It does not depend on J or E_l . Put $c_y = a_{1y} a_{y1}$, $e_1 = k_m + k_n + k_h$, $e_2 = k_m k_n + k_m k_h + k_n k_h$, $e_3 = k_m k_n k_h$. Then

$$(a) \det(\lambda I - A) = p(\lambda) = \lambda^4 + a_1 \lambda^3 + a_2 \lambda^2 + a_3 \lambda + a_4 \text{ with } a_1 = e_1 - a_{11}, a_2 = e_2 - a_{11} e_1 - \sum_y c_y, \\ a_3 = e_3 - a_{11} e_2 - \sum_y c_y \sum_{y' \neq y} k_{y'} \text{ and } a_4 = -a_{11} e_3 - \sum_y c_y \prod_{y' \neq y} k_{y'};$$

$$(b) a_4 = e_3 J'_{ss}(u);$$

(c) if $p(\lambda) = 0$ and $\lambda \notin \{-k_m, -k_n, -k_h\}$, then

$$q = \left(1, \frac{a_{m1}}{\lambda + k_m}, \frac{a_{n1}}{\lambda + k_n}, \frac{a_{h1}}{\lambda + k_h}\right), \quad w = \left(1, \frac{a_{1m}}{\lambda + k_m}, \frac{a_{1n}}{\lambda + k_n}, \frac{a_{1h}}{\lambda + k_h}\right)$$

satisfy $Aq = \lambda q$ and $w^T A = \lambda w^T$.

Proof. The entries follow by differentiating (1); $a_{y1} = \alpha'_y \beta_y / k_y - \beta'_y \alpha_y / k_y = k_y y'_\infty$. For $\lambda \notin \{-k_y\}$ the Schur complement of the diagonal block gives $\det(\lambda I - A) = \prod_y (\lambda + k_y) (\lambda - a_{11} - \sum_y c_y / (\lambda + k_y))$, a polynomial identity that holds for all λ ; expanding it gives (a). For (b), $J'_{ss} = \partial_u I + \sum_y \partial_y I y'_\infty = -a_{11} - \sum_y a_{1y} a_{y1} / k_y$, and multiplying by e_3 gives the expression for a_4 . For (c), rows 2 to 4 of $(A - \lambda)q = 0$ read $a_{y1} - (k_y + \lambda)q_y = 0$, and row 1 reads $a_{11} + \sum_y c_y / (\lambda + k_y) - \lambda = 0$, which is $p(\lambda) / \prod_y (\lambda + k_y) = 0$; w is checked in the same way. $\square$

Below, $D_2 = a_1 a_2 - a_3$ and $D_3 = a_1 a_2 a_3 - a_3^2 - a_1^2 a_4 = a_3 D_2 - a_1^2 a_4$ are the Hurwitz determinants of p ; like the a_k , they are functions of u alone.

2.4 Periodic orbits

Let φ_t be the flow of (1) for fixed (J, E_l) and Γ a periodic orbit of minimal period T . The *Floquet multipliers* of Γ are the eigenvalues of the monodromy matrix $D\varphi_T(y)$, $y \in \Gamma$, which do not depend on y up to similarity; $f(y)$ is an eigenvector for the multiplier 1. For a hyperplane $\Sigma = \{x_i = c\}$ with $f_i(y) > 0$ at $y \in \Gamma \cap \Sigma$, the first-return map P is defined near y on Σ (Section 5), and the *nontrivial* multipliers are the eigenvalues of $DP(y)$; by Lemma 5.8 they are the multipliers other than one copy of 1. Γ is *orbitally asymptotically stable* if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is $\delta > 0$ such that $\text{dist}(x, \Gamma) < \delta$ implies $\text{dist}(\varphi_t(x), \Gamma) < \varepsilon$ for all $t \geq 0$ and $\text{dist}(\varphi_t(x), \Gamma) \rightarrow 0$; it is *not orbitally stable* if the first property fails. We call Γ *of saddle type* if one nontrivial multiplier is real and larger than 1 and the others have modulus less than 1. The sections used are $\Sigma_{20} = \{u = 20\}$ and $\Sigma_5 = \{u = 5\}$, crossed with $\dot{u} > 0$, with coordinates (m, n, h) .

3 Results

Theorem 1 (computer-assisted). *For every $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$ and every $J \in [0, 200]$ the system (1) has exactly one equilibrium $x^*(u^*(J))$, and $-12 < u^*(J) < 115$. The function $J \mapsto u^*(J)$ is real-analytic and strictly increasing.*

Theorem 2 (computer-assisted). *Let $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$. The coefficients a_1, a_3, a_4 of Lemma 2.4 are positive on $[-12, 115]$, and D_3 has exactly two zeros there, both simple, $u_{H1} \in [5.345856397004, 5.345856397005]$ and $u_{H2} \in [21.941907987016, 21.941907987017]$, with $D_3 > 0$ on $[-12, u_{H1}) \cup (u_{H2}, 115]$ and $D_3 < 0$ on (u_{H1}, u_{H2}) . Put $J_{Hi} = J_{ss}(u_{Hi})$. Then:*

- (a) *For $J \in [0, J_{H1}) \cup (J_{H2}, 200]$ every eigenvalue of the equilibrium has negative real part, so the equilibrium is locally asymptotically stable. For $J \in (J_{H1}, J_{H2})$ exactly two eigenvalues, counted with multiplicity, have positive real part, none lies on the imaginary axis, and the equilibrium is unstable.*
- (b) *At $J = J_{Hi}$ the eigenvalues are a simple pair $\pm i\omega_i$ and two eigenvalues with negative real part, with $\omega_1 \in [0.586233813130, 0.586233813131]$ and $\omega_2 \in [1.062921806760, 1.062921806761]$ ms^{-1} ($2\pi/\omega_1 \in [10.717882807, 10.717882808]$ ms , $2\pi/\omega_2 \in [5.911239441, 5.911239442]$ ms).*

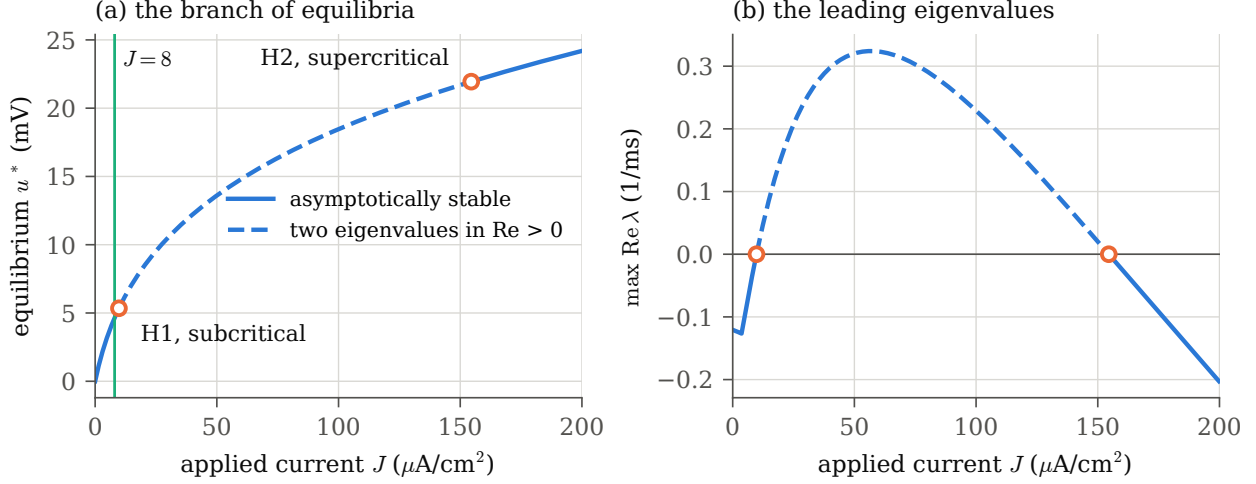


Figure 1: The branch of equilibria at $E_l = 10.613$ (code/make_figures.py). (a) $u^*(J)$ for $J \in [0, 200]$, solid where the equilibrium is asymptotically stable and dashed where it has two eigenvalues with positive real part; circles: the Hopf points of Theorem 2; the vertical line is $J = 8$, the current of Theorems 4 and 5. (b) The largest real part of an eigenvalue. The curves are floating-point evaluations; the positions of the Hopf points and the stability types are those proved in Theorem 2.

(c) $J_{Hi}(E_l) = J_{Hi}(10.613) + 0.3(10.613 - E_l)$, with the values ($\mu A/cm^2$)

E_l	J_{H1}	J_{H2}
10.613	[9.775437995393, 9.775437995394]	[154.522433665808, 154.522433665809]
E_l^*	[9.779661704575, 9.779661704576]	[154.526657374990, 154.526657374991]
10.599	[9.779637995393, 9.779637995394]	[154.526633665808, 154.526633665809]
[10.59, 10.62]	[9.773337995, 9.782337996]	[154.520333665, 154.529333666]

(d) The eigenvalue $\lambda(J)$ with $\lambda(J_{Hi}) = i\omega_i$ crosses the imaginary axis transversally: $\text{Re } \lambda'(J_{H1}) \in [0.01878905889, 0.01878905890]$ and $\text{Re } \lambda'(J_{H2}) \in [-0.00449227917, -0.00449227916]$.

(e) The first Lyapunov coefficient (3), with the eigenvector q normalized by $\langle q, q \rangle = 1$ in the coordinates (u, m, n, h) (u in mV, t in ms), is $\ell_1(H1) \in [0.01479364813100, 0.01479364813101] > 0$ and $\ell_1(H2) \in [-0.004728502695074, -0.004728502695073] < 0$.

The value of ℓ_1 depends on the normalization of q ; its sign does not. Figure 1 shows the branch.

Corollary 3 (computer-assisted, with the cited Theorem 4.5). *Let $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$. Near $(x^*(J_{Hi}), J_{Hi})$ the one-parameter family (1), with parameter J , is locally topologically equivalent to the suspension of the Hopf normal form by a two-dimensional stable node, with $\sigma = +1$ at J_{H1} and $\sigma = -1$ at J_{H2} (Theorem 4.5). Consequently, in the neighbourhood where the equivalence holds:*

- (a) (subcritical) for $J < J_{H1}$ close to J_{H1} , where the equilibrium is stable, there is a limit cycle, and it is not orbitally stable; for $J \geq J_{H1}$ close to J_{H1} there is none;
- (b) (supercritical) for $J < J_{H2}$ close to J_{H2} , where the equilibrium is unstable, there is an orbitally asymptotically stable limit cycle; for $J \geq J_{H2}$ close to J_{H2} there is none.

The corollary is local: it gives no bound on how far from J_{Hi} the cycles persist. That the saddle-type orbit of Theorem 5(b) at $J = 8$ belongs to the family born at J_{H1} is numerical evidence only (Section 8).

Table 1: Theorem 5(a), the stable orbit Γ_s on Σ_{20} at $J = 8$: the minimal period (ms) and the nontrivial Floquet multipliers. Every bound is rounded outward from the program's balls (`data/certify_bistability.txt`, stages 4 and 7).

E_l	T_s	μ_1	bound on $ \mu_2 , \mu_3 $
10.613	[16.00771280383, 16.00771280384]	$ \mu_1 - 0.070896780693 \leq 2.25 \cdot 10^{-9}$	$3.97 \cdot 10^{-9}$
E_l^*	[16.01150429806, 16.01150429807]	$ \mu_1 - 0.070904264160 \leq 2.26 \cdot 10^{-9}$	$3.99 \cdot 10^{-9}$
10.599	[16.01148299894, 16.01148299895]	$ \mu_1 - 0.070904221789 \leq 2.26 \cdot 10^{-9}$	$3.99 \cdot 10^{-9}$

Table 2: Theorem 5(b), the saddle-type orbit Γ_u on Σ_5 at $J = 8$.

E_l	T_u	μ_1 (real)	μ_2	bound on $ \mu_3 $
10.613	[14.34360094, 14.34360095]	[10.30268246, 10.30308318]	$ \mu_2 - 0.1968322291 \leq 2.72 \cdot 10^{-4}$	$1.57 \cdot 10^{-4}$
E_l^*	[14.36944974, 14.36944975]	[10.52978728, 10.53004150]	$ \mu_2 - 0.1971756106 \leq 1.78 \cdot 10^{-4}$	$9.49 \cdot 10^{-5}$
10.599	[14.36930333, 14.36930334]	[10.52836245, 10.52886553]	$ \mu_2 - 0.1971736153 \leq 3.51 \cdot 10^{-4}$	$1.88 \cdot 10^{-4}$

Table 3: The section points (m, n, h) of Theorem 5: each lies in the product of the three intervals, which contains the Krawczyk box of the proof.

orbit, E_l	m	n	h
Γ_s , 10.613	[0.24052906069, 0.24052906070]	[0.42490470823, 0.42490470824]	[0.39231037641, 0.39231037642]
Γ_s , E_l^*	[0.24053257124, 0.24053257125]	[0.42490307734, 0.42490307735]	[0.39231449643, 0.39231449644]
Γ_s , 10.599	[0.24053255147, 0.24053255148]	[0.42490308639, 0.42490308640]	[0.39231447350, 0.39231447351]
Γ_u , 10.613	[0.09004142752, 0.09004142753]	[0.37950318996, 0.37950318997]	[0.43754826309, 0.43754826310]
Γ_u , E_l^*	[0.09003971888, 0.09003971889]	[0.37946676035, 0.37946676036]	[0.43755923369, 0.43755923370]
Γ_u , 10.599	[0.09003972849, 0.09003972850]	[0.37946696511, 0.37946696512]	[0.43755917467, 0.43755917468]

Theorem 4 (computer-assisted). *Let $J = 8$. For every $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$ the system (1) has a periodic orbit $\Gamma(E_l)$ that crosses Σ_{20} with $\dot{u} > 0$ once per period, whose minimal period lies in $[16.005827509, 16.013912063]$ ms, along which u reaches at least 95.953 mV, and whose nontrivial Floquet multipliers satisfy $|\mu| \leq 0.5446$. It is orbitally asymptotically stable. Its point on Σ_{20} is the only fixed point of the first-return map in a box of radius about $4.6 \cdot 10^{-7}$ (Section 6).*

So the firing frequency $1000/T$ lies in $[62.445, 62.478]$ Hz. Figure 3(a) shows the period enclosures.

Theorem 5 (computer-assisted). *Let $J = 8$ and let E_l be one of 10.613, E_l^* (the statement holds for every E_l in the ball $[10.598920969391678522198878, 10.598920969391678522198879]$, which contains E_l^*) and 10.599.*

- (a) *There is a periodic orbit Γ_s through Σ_{20} , crossed with $\dot{u} > 0$, with minimal period T_s and nontrivial multipliers μ_1, μ_2, μ_3 as in Table 1; μ_1 is enclosed in a disc that holds exactly one multiplier. u reaches at least 95.953532, 95.953707 and 95.953706 mV along Γ_s (in the order of the three values of E_l). Γ_s is orbitally asymptotically stable.*
- (b) *There is a periodic orbit Γ_u through Σ_5 , crossed with $\dot{u} > 0$, with minimal period T_u and multipliers as in Table 2: μ_1 is real and larger than 1, $|\mu_2| < 1$ and $|\mu_3| < 1$. Γ_u is of saddle type and not orbitally stable, and $u \leq 11.045813, 11.073821$ and 11.073666 mV along it.*
- (c) *Γ_s , Γ_u and the equilibrium are three distinct invariant sets. The section points of Γ_s and Γ_u are the only fixed points of the first-return maps in their boxes (Table 3); nothing is claimed about other periodic orbits.*

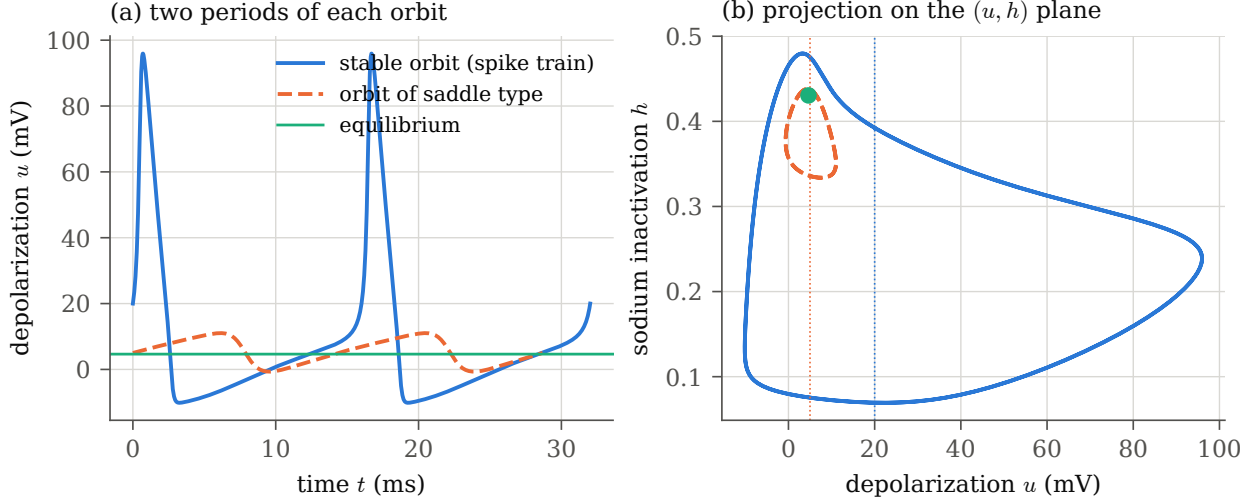


Figure 2: The orbits of Theorem 5 at $J = 8$, $E_l = 10.613$, integrated in floating point from the high-precision section points of Section 8 (`code/make_figures.py`). (a) $u(t)$ over two periods of the stable orbit Γ_s (solid) and of the saddle-type orbit Γ_u (dashed), and the equilibrium u^* . (b) The projection on the (u, h) plane, with the sections $u = 20$ and $u = 5$ (dotted) and the equilibrium (dot). The enclosures of the theorems are far narrower than the lines.

Corollary 6 (computer-assisted). *For $J = 8$ and every $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$, equivalently for $E_l = 10.613$ and every $J \in [7.9931, 8.0021]$, the system (1) has a locally asymptotically stable equilibrium and an orbitally asymptotically stable periodic orbit. At $E_l = 10.613$, E_l^* and 10.599 it also has a periodic orbit of saddle type.*

Remark 3.1 (what is not claimed). We do not claim that the equilibrium and $\Gamma(E_l)$ are the only attractors, nor anything about their basins, nor that Γ_u lies on the boundary between the basins; numerically it does lie on a separatrix [24, p. 62]. The orbits are unique only in their boxes. We have not checked that the box of Theorem 5(a) lies in the box of Theorem 4 at the same E_l , so we do not claim that $\Gamma_s = \Gamma(E_l)$, although numerically they coincide. Nothing is proved about periodic orbits at currents other than $J = 8$ (and those equivalent to it by Lemma 2.2), about the fold of cycles that numerically bounds the bistable range from below, or about the equilibria for $J > 200$.

4 Proofs for the branch of equilibria

4.1 Lemmas

Lemma 4.1 (proved). *Let $p(\lambda) = \lambda^4 + a_1\lambda^3 + a_2\lambda^2 + a_3\lambda + a_4$ be real with $a_1, a_3, a_4 > 0$, $D_2 = a_1a_2 - a_3$ and $D_3 = a_3D_2 - a_1^2a_4$.*

- (a) *p has a root on the imaginary axis if and only if $D_3 = 0$. In that case, with $\omega = \sqrt{a_3/a_1} > 0$, $p(\lambda) = (\lambda^2 + \omega^2)(\lambda^2 + a_1\lambda + a_4/\omega^2)$, the roots $\pm i\omega$ are simple and the other two roots have negative real part.*
- (b) *If $D_3 > 0$, then $D_2 > 0$ and every root has negative real part.*
- (c) *If $D_3 < 0$, then exactly two roots, counted with multiplicity, have positive real part.*

Proof. (a) $p(0) = a_4 \neq 0$. For real $\omega \neq 0$, $p(i\omega) = \omega^4 - a_2\omega^2 + a_4 + i\omega(a_3 - a_1\omega^2)$, so $p(i\omega) = 0$ if and only if $\omega^2 = a_3/a_1$ and $\omega^4 - a_2\omega^2 + a_4 = 0$; with $\omega^2 = a_3/a_1$ the second condition reads $(a_3^2 - a_1a_2a_3 + a_1^2a_4)/a_1^2 = -D_3/a_1^2 = 0$. Expanding $(\lambda^2 + \omega^2)(\lambda^2 + a_1\lambda + c)$ gives $\lambda^4 + a_1\lambda^3 + (c + \omega^2)\lambda^2 + a_1\omega^2\lambda + c\omega^2$; with $c = a_4/\omega^2$ the last two coefficients are a_3 and a_4 , and $c + \omega^2 = a_2$ is equivalent to $a_1^2a_4 + a_3^2 = a_1a_2a_3$, that is $D_3 = 0$. The quadratic $\lambda^2 + a_1\lambda + a_4/\omega^2$ has positive coefficients, so its roots have negative real part; it does not vanish at $\pm i\omega$, so these roots are simple.

(b), (c) If $D_3 > 0$ then $a_3D_2 = D_3 + a_1^2a_4 > 0$, so $D_2 > 0$. Let $Q = \{(a_1, \dots, a_4) : a_1, a_3, a_4 > 0\}$ and $N(a)$ the number of roots of p in $\{\operatorname{Re} \lambda > 0\}$. The roots of a monic polynomial depend continuously on its coefficients, so N is locally constant on the set of coefficient vectors for which no root lies on the imaginary axis (a root can enter or leave the open right half-plane only through the axis). By (a) this set, within Q , is $\{D_3 \neq 0\}$. Now $D_3 > 0$ is equivalent to $a_2 > \theta(a_1, a_3, a_4) := a_3/a_1 + a_1a_4/a_3$, a continuous function on $(0, \infty)^3$, so $Q \cap \{D_3 > 0\}$ is connected, and so is $Q \cap \{D_3 < 0\} = \{a_2 < \theta\}$. Hence N is constant on each. $(\lambda + 1)^4$ has $(a_1, a_2, a_3, a_4) = (4, 6, 4, 1)$, $D_3 = 64 > 0$ and $N = 0$; $(\lambda^2 - \lambda + 1)(\lambda^2 + 3\lambda + 1) = \lambda^4 + 2\lambda^3 - \lambda^2 + 2\lambda + 1$ has $D_3 = -12 < 0$ and $N = 2$, the roots of $\lambda^2 - \lambda + 1$ having real part $1/2$ and those of $\lambda^2 + 3\lambda + 1$ being negative. $\square$

Lemma 4.2 (proved). *If every eigenvalue of $A = Df(x_0)$ at an equilibrium x_0 of a C^2 vector field has negative real part, x_0 is locally asymptotically stable.*

Proof. There are $K, \gamma > 0$ with $\|e^{At}\| \leq Ke^{-\gamma t}$, so $P = \int_0^\infty e^{A^T t} e^{At} dt$ exists, is symmetric positive definite and satisfies $A^T P + PA = -I$ (integrate $\frac{d}{dt} e^{A^T t} e^{At}$). Write $f(x_0 + y) = Ay + g(y)$ with $|g(y)| \leq L|y|^2$ for $|y| \leq 1$ and put $V(y) = y^T P y$. Along solutions $\dot{V} = -|y|^2 + 2y^T P g(y) \leq -|y|^2/2$ for $|y| \leq r_0 = \min(1, 1/(4L\|P\|))$. With $\lambda_{\min}|y|^2 \leq V \leq \lambda_{\max}|y|^2$ (λ the extreme eigenvalues of P), the set $\{V < \lambda_{\min}r_0^2\}$ lies in $\{|y| < r_0\}$, is positively invariant, and on it $\dot{V} \leq -V/(2\lambda_{\max})$, so $V(y(t)) \leq V(y(0))e^{-t/(2\lambda_{\max})} \rightarrow 0$. This gives stability and attraction. $\square$

Lemma 4.3 (proved). *If $A = Df(x_0)$ at an equilibrium x_0 of a C^2 vector field has an eigenvalue with positive real part, x_0 is not stable.*

Proof. Let $4\gamma > 0$ be the smallest positive real part of an eigenvalue of A , and split $\mathbb{R}^n = E_+ \oplus E_-$ into the invariant subspaces of the eigenvalues with positive and with nonpositive real part, $A = \operatorname{diag}(A_+, A_-)$ in adapted coordinates $y = (y_+, y_-)$. For a real matrix all of whose eigenvalues have real part at least 4γ (at most 0) there is an inner product with $\langle A_+ v, v \rangle \geq 3\gamma|v|^2$ (with $\langle A_- v, v \rangle \leq \gamma|v|^2$): use a basis in which the matrix is in real Jordan form with off-diagonal entries scaled below γ . With these inner products on $E_\pm$, put $V(y) = |y_+|^2 - |y_-|^2$ and write $f(x_0 + y) = Ay + g(y)$, $|g(y)| \leq L|y|^2$. Then $\dot{V} \geq 6\gamma|y_+|^2 - 2\gamma|y_-|^2 - 4L|y|^3$. On the cone $\{V > 0\}$, $|y| \leq \sqrt{2}|y_+|$, so $\dot{V} \geq 4\gamma|y_+|^2 - 4\sqrt{8}L|y_+|^3 \geq 2\gamma|y_+|^2 \geq 2\gamma V$ when $|y| \leq r_0$ for a suitable $r_0 > 0$. A solution starting in the cone with $|y(0)|$ arbitrarily small stays in it while $|y| \leq r_0$, and V grows at least like $e^{2\gamma t}$ there, so it leaves the ball of radius r_0 . $\square$

Lemma 4.4 (proved). (a) $|B_n|/n! \leq 4/(2\pi)^n$ for every $n \geq 0$. Hence, for a real ball X with $|x| \leq r < 3$ on X and $0 \leq k < N + 2 - (N + 2)r/(2\pi)$, the k -th Taylor coefficient of Ψ at $x \in X$ is $\sum_{n=k}^N \frac{B_n}{n!} \binom{n}{k} x^{n-k} + \theta$ with $|\theta| \leq \frac{4 \binom{N+1}{k} r^{N+1-k}}{(2\pi)^{N+1}(1-\rho)}$, $\rho = \frac{N+2}{N+2-k} \cdot \frac{r}{2\pi}$. (b) $E(w) = (e^w - 1)/w = 1/\Psi(w)$ is entire and positive on $\mathbb{R}$, and its Taylor coefficients $e_j(w) = E^{(j)}(w)/j!$ satisfy $e_j(w) = \frac{1}{j!} \int_0^1 s^j e^{sw} ds = {}_1F_1(j+1; j+2; w)/(j+1)!$. Each e_j is strictly increasing in w , so on an interval $[w_-, w_+]$ it lies between $e_j(w_-)$ and $e_j(w_+)$.

Proof. (a) $\Psi(x) = \sum_n B_n x^n/n!$ for $|x| < 2\pi$ [6, eq. 24.2.1] with $B_0 = 1$, $B_1 = -1/2$ and $B_n = 0$ for odd $n \geq 3$ [6, Sect. 24.2]. For even $n \geq 2$, $|B_n|/n! = 2\zeta(n)/(2\pi)^n$ [6, eq. 25.6.2] and $\zeta(n) \leq$

$\zeta(2) = \pi^2/6$, so $|B_n|/n! \leq (\pi^2/3)/(2\pi)^n < 4/(2\pi)^n$; for $n = 0, 1$ the bound reads $1 \leq 4$ and $1/2 \leq 2/\pi$. Differentiating the series k times, the tail $n > N$ of the k -th coefficient is bounded by $\sum_{n>N} 4 \binom{n}{k} r^{n-k}/(2\pi)^n$, whose ratio of consecutive terms, $\frac{n+1}{n+1-k} \cdot \frac{r}{2\pi}$, decreases in n and is at most $\rho < 1$ for $n \geq N+1$; a geometric series gives the bound. (b) $E(w) = \int_0^1 e^{sw} ds$ is entire and positive for real w , so $e_j(w) = \frac{1}{j!} \int_0^1 s^j e^{sw} ds$, and its derivative $\frac{1}{j!} \int_0^1 s^{j+1} e^{sw} ds$ is positive. Expanding e^{sw} , $\int_0^1 s^j e^{sw} ds = \sum_{k \geq 0} \frac{w^k}{k!(j+k+1)}$, while ${}_1F_1(j+1; j+2; w) = \sum_{k \geq 0} \frac{(j+1)_k}{(j+2)_k} \frac{w^k}{k!} = \sum_{k \geq 0} \frac{j+1}{j+1+k} \frac{w^k}{k!}$ by the definition of Kummer's function [6, eq. 13.2.2]. $\square$

The program for Theorems 1 and 2 (`code/hh_ball.py`) evaluates Ψ through (a) with $N = 240$ where $|x| < 3$ and through its closed form elsewhere, where it refuses any ball containing 0; the program for Theorems 4 and 5 (`code/hh_arb.py`) evaluates the Taylor coefficients of E through (b), with ${}_1F_1$ from Arb [19], and those of Ψ as the reciprocal series. The two implementations give overlapping enclosures of E_l^* (the self-test of `data/certify_equilibria_hopf.txt`, part 0).

The first Lyapunov coefficient. Let A have a simple pair of eigenvalues $\pm i\omega$, $\omega > 0$, let $Aq = i\omega q$, $A^T p = -i\omega p$ and $\langle p, q \rangle = \bar{p}^T q = 1$, and write the Taylor expansion of the vector field at the equilibrium x_0 as $f(x_0 + y) = Ay + \frac{1}{2}B(y, y) + \frac{1}{6}C(y, y, y) + O(|y|^4)$ with symmetric multilinear B and C . Then

$$\ell_1 = \frac{1}{2\omega} \operatorname{Re} \left(\langle p, C(q, q, \bar{q}) \rangle - 2 \langle p, B(q, A^{-1}B(q, \bar{q})) \rangle + \langle p, B(\bar{q}, (2i\omega I - A)^{-1}B(q, q)) \rangle \right), \quad (3)$$

as given by Kuznetsov [22, Sect. “First Lyapunov Coefficient”], who cites his book [21] for it. We use it through the following theorem.

Theorem 4.5 (cited: [22, Sects. “Multi-dimensional Case” and “First Lyapunov Coefficient”]). *Let $\dot{x} = f(x, \alpha)$, $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $\alpha \in \mathbb{R}$, with f smooth, have a family of equilibria $x^0(\alpha)$ whose Jacobian $A(\alpha)$ has one pair of complex eigenvalues $\mu(\alpha) \pm i\omega(\alpha)$ with $\mu(0) = 0$, $\omega(0) = \omega_0 > 0$, and at $\alpha = 0$ a simple pair $\pm i\omega_0$, n_s eigenvalues with negative and n_u with positive real part, $n_s + n_u + 2 = n$. If $\ell_1(0) \neq 0$ (computed by (3) at $\alpha = 0$) and $\mu'(0) \neq 0$, the system is locally topologically equivalent near the origin to the suspension of the normal form*

$$\dot{y}_1 = \beta y_1 - y_2 + \sigma y_1(y_1^2 + y_2^2), \quad \dot{y}_2 = y_1 + \beta y_2 + \sigma y_2(y_1^2 + y_2^2), \quad \dot{y}^s = -y^s, \quad \dot{y}^u = y^u,$$

$y^s \in \mathbb{R}^{n_s}$, $y^u \in \mathbb{R}^{n_u}$, $\sigma = \operatorname{sign} \ell_1(0)$. For $\sigma = +1$ the origin of the planar normal form is asymptotically stable for $\beta < 0$ and unstable for $\beta \geq 0$, and a unique limit cycle, unstable, exists for $\beta < 0$; for $\sigma = -1$ the origin is asymptotically stable for $\beta \leq 0$ and unstable for $\beta > 0$, and a unique limit cycle, stable, exists for $\beta > 0$.

We have checked (3) and Theorem 4.5 against [22] only, not against the book; Section 10 says so again. The implementation of (3) is tested on systems whose ℓ_1 is known independently: the planar formula of Guckenheimer and Holmes as printed in [22], and the following four-dimensional system, whose ℓ_1 we compute through the centre manifold.

Lemma 4.6 (proved). *For $\omega, a, e > 0$ and real ς, b, c, d, ϕ , the system*

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{x}_1 &= -\omega x_2 + \varsigma x_1 r^2 + c x_1 x_3 + \phi x_1 x_4, & \dot{x}_3 &= -a x_3 + b r^2, \\ \dot{x}_2 &= \omega x_1 + \varsigma x_2 r^2 + c x_2 x_3 - \phi x_2 x_4, & \dot{x}_4 &= -e x_4 + d(x_1^2 - x_2^2), \end{aligned} \quad r^2 = x_1^2 + x_2^2,$$

has, at the origin and with $q = p = (1, -i, 0, 0)/\sqrt{2}$, the first Lyapunov coefficient $\ell_1 = \frac{2}{\omega}(\varsigma + \frac{bc}{a} + \frac{d\phi e}{2(e^2 + 4\omega^2)})$, that is, $\ell_1 = \operatorname{Re} c_1/\omega$ where c_1 is the coefficient of $w|w|^2$ in the equation on the centre manifold in the coordinate w with $x = wq + \bar{w}\bar{q} + O(|w|^2)$.

Proof. With $z = x_1 + ix_2$, the linear part is $\dot{z} = i\omega z$ on the centre subspace. A centre manifold is a graph $x_3 = h_3(z)$, $x_4 = h_4(z)$ with $h_{3,4} = O(|z|^2)$; its quadratic parts solve the homological equations. For $h_3 = \eta_3|z|^2$: $\frac{d}{dt}|z|^2 = 0$ along the linear flow, so $-a\eta_3|z|^2 + b|z|^2 = 0$, $\eta_3 = b/a$. For $h_4 = \text{Re}(\kappa z^2)$: $\frac{d}{dt}\text{Re}(\kappa z^2) = \text{Re}(2i\omega\kappa z^2)$ along the linear flow and $x_1^2 - x_2^2 = \text{Re}(z^2)$, so $2i\omega\kappa = -e\kappa + d$, $\kappa = d/(e + 2i\omega)$. On the manifold, $\dot{z} = \dot{x}_1 + i\dot{x}_2 = i\omega z + \varsigma z|z|^2 + czh_3 + \phi\bar{z}h_4 + O(|z|^4)$, because $x_1x_4 - ix_2x_3 = \bar{z}x_4$, and the terms of $h_{3,4}$ of order three contribute only at order four. Since $\phi\bar{z}\text{Re}(\kappa z^2) = \frac{\phi}{2}(\kappa z^2\bar{z} + \bar{\kappa}\bar{z}^3)$, the coefficient of $z^2\bar{z}$ is $\varsigma + cb/a + \phi\kappa/2$. There are no quadratic terms, so this is the resonant cubic coefficient in z . With $x = wq + \bar{w}\bar{q}$ on the centre subspace we have $z = \sqrt{2}w$, so the coefficient in w is $c_1 = 2(\varsigma + cb/a + \phi\kappa/2)$, and $\text{Re } c_1/\omega = \frac{2}{\omega}(\varsigma + \frac{bc}{a} + \frac{\phi}{2}\text{Re } \kappa)$ with $\text{Re } \kappa = de/(e^2 + 4\omega^2)$. Evaluating (3) directly gives the same value: $\langle p, C(q, q, \bar{q}) \rangle = 4\varsigma$, $B(q, \bar{q}) = (0, 0, 2b, 0)$, $\langle p, B(q, A^{-1}B(q, \bar{q})) \rangle = -2bc/a$, $B(q, q) = (0, 0, 0, 2d)$ and $\langle p, B(\bar{q}, (2i\omega - A)^{-1}B(q, q)) \rangle = 2d\phi/(e + 2i\omega)$. $\square$

The program runs the implementation of (3) on two planar test systems and on the system of Lemma 4.6 with $(\omega, \varsigma, a, b, c, d, e, \phi) = (1, -\frac{1}{10}, 2, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, 1)$ and with $\omega = \frac{3}{2}$, $\varsigma = -\frac{1}{5}$; the known values of ℓ_1 are $[-0.160416666667, -0.160416666666]$, $[0.125573192239, 0.125573192240]$, $[0.143137254901, 0.143137254902]$ and $[-0.101501501502, -0.101501501501]$, of both signs, and the implementation reproduces each to within 10^{-60} . Two mutated versions, with $+2$ in place of -2 in the middle term and with $(-A)^{-1}$ in place of $(2i\omega I - A)^{-1}$, give $[-0.19019608, -0.19019607]$ and $[2.96666666, 2.96666667]$ on the first coupled system and are refused (negative controls).

4.2 Proofs

All references to checks are to `data/certify_equilibria_hopf.txt`, written by `code/certify_equilibria_hopf.py` at 256 bits; the model is `code/hh_ball.py`, which evaluates every quantity as a truncated power series in u over complex balls, so that a series evaluated on a ball U encloses the Taylor coefficients of the quantity at every point of U . The leak potential enters as the ball $[10.605 \pm 0.015] \supset [10.59, 10.62]$.

Proof of Proposition 2.3. $I(x^*(0)) = 0$ is linear in E_l and gives the formula. The program evaluates it in ball arithmetic (part 0 of the output), and the independent implementation of `code/hh_arb.py` gives an overlapping ball. The current at $u = 0$ for $E_l = 10.613$ is $I(x^*(0)) = g_l(E_l^* - 10.613)$, since I depends on E_l only through $-g_l E_l$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 1. By Lemma 2.1(d) we must count the solutions of $J_{ss}(u) = J$. For $u < -12$ each of the three terms of $J_{ss}(u) = g_{Na}m^3h(u - 115) + g_Kn^4(u + 12) + g_l(u - E_l)$ is negative (Lemma 2.1(a) and $E_l > -12$), so $J_{ss}(u) < 0 \leq J$. For $u \geq 115$ the first term is nonnegative, the third positive, and the second at least $g_K n_\infty (115)^4 \cdot 127$ by Lemma 2.1(b); the program encloses this number and finds it at least $4089.4815 > 200$ (part A, third check). On $[-12, 115]$ the program shows $J'_{ss} > 0$ on each of 74 pieces of a subdivision (part A, first check), so J_{ss} is strictly increasing there, and it shows $J_{ss}(-12) \leq -6.7999 < 0$ and $J_{ss}(115) > 200$ (fourth check) for every E_l in the ball. For $J \in [0, 200]$ the intermediate value theorem and monotonicity give exactly one solution, and it lies in $(-12, 115)$. J_{ss} is real-analytic with positive derivative there, so its inverse u^* is real-analytic and increasing. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 2. Signs along the branch. The program subdivides $[-12, 115]$ into 1043 pieces and shows on each that $a_1, a_3, a_4 > 0$ and that $D_3 > 0$ or $D_3 < 0$, except on 52 pieces of width below 10^{-5} (part B, first check). These undecided pieces form two clusters, $[5.345749617, 5.345961571]$ and $[21.941817522, 21.941999197]$ (second check); every zero of D_3 in $[-12, 115]$ lies in them. On each cluster, slightly enlarged, the program encloses dD_3/du in $[-4.121, -4.109]$ and $[176.1, 176.6]$

respectively and shows that D_3 has opposite signs at the two ends (third and fifth checks), so each cluster contains exactly one zero, and it is simple. Interval Newton steps $N(X) = m - D_3(m)/D'_3(X)$, m the midpoint of X , are applied as long as $N(X) \subset X$; by the mean value theorem the zero $u_H \in X$ satisfies $u_H = m - D_3(m)/D'_3(\xi)$ for some $\xi \in X$, so it stays in the new box, which gives u_{H1} and u_{H2} in balls of radius at most $2.28 \cdot 10^{-73}$ and $3.69 \cdot 10^{-73}$ (fourth and sixth checks; Theorem 2 prints them rounded outward to 12 decimals). The program shows $D_3 > 0$ at $u = -12$ and $u = 115$ and $D_3 < 0$ at a point between the zeros (seventh check), which fixes the signs on the three intervals.

(a) and (b). By Theorem 1 the equilibrium at current J has $u^*(J) \in (-12, 115)$, and $u^*(J) < u_{H1}$ exactly when $J < J_{H1}$, since u^* is increasing; similarly for u_{H2} . Lemma 4.1(b) gives the stable ranges, and Lemma 4.2 local asymptotic stability; Lemma 4.1(c) and (a) give the count on (J_{H1}, J_{H2}) and the absence of roots on the axis, and Lemma 4.3 the instability; Lemma 4.1(a) gives (b), with $\omega_i^2 = a_3/a_1$ at u_{Hi} , enclosed by the program. The program also checks, as a guard against coding errors, that $a_2 - \omega^2 - a_4/\omega^2$ encloses 0 at u_{Hi} and that the Routh array at the midpoint of (u_{H1}, u_{H2}) has two sign changes; both are consequences of Lemma 4.1, not steps of the proof.

(c). $J_{Hi} = J_{ss}(u_{Hi})$ is evaluated on the ball of u_{Hi} for each value of E_l , and for E_l^* on its ball; Lemma 2.2 gives the affine dependence and the range over $[10.59, 10.62]$, whose ends are the values at 10.62 and 10.59 (part C).

(d). The coefficients a_k are real-analytic in u , and $i\omega_i$ is a simple root of $p(\cdot; u_{Hi})$, so by the implicit function theorem there is an analytic root $\lambda(u)$ with $\lambda(u_{Hi}) = i\omega_i$ and $\lambda'(u) = -\partial_u p / \partial_{\lambda} p$. The program encloses $\text{Re } \lambda'(u_{Hi})$ in $[0.0501908689, 0.0501908690]$ and $[-0.0824086729, -0.0824086728]$, and $J'_{ss}(u_{Hi})$ in $[2.67128168, 2.67128169]$ and $[18.34451285, 18.34451286]$; the eigenvalue as a function of J is $\lambda(u^*(J))$, with derivative $\lambda'(u)/J'_{ss}(u)$, enclosed as stated.

(e). By Lemma 2.4(c) with $\lambda = i\omega_i$, the closed-form vectors q and w satisfy $Aq = i\omega q$ and $w^T A = i\omega w^T$ (the program also checks that the residuals enclose 0). The program normalizes $\langle q, q \rangle = 1$ and $w^T q = 1$, and puts $p = \bar{w}$, so that $A^T p = -i\omega p$ and $\langle p, q \rangle = 1$. It obtains B and C from the vector field evaluated as a power series in t along $x^*(u_{Hi}) + tv$: the coefficients of t^2 and t^3 are $\frac{1}{2}B(v, v)$ and $\frac{1}{6}C(v, v, v)$, and $B(v, v')$, $C(q, q, \bar{q})$ follow by polarization. A^{-1} and $(2i\omega I - A)^{-1}$ are applied by Arb's rigorous linear solver. ℓ_1 does not depend on J or E_l , which enter f additively. The resulting enclosures exclude 0 (part C). A non-rigorous recomputation with SymPy derivatives and mpmath eigenvectors agrees to a relative $3.23 \cdot 10^{-40}$ and $6.24 \cdot 10^{-41}$. $\square$

Proof of Corollary 3. Fix E_l and i , and put $\alpha = J - J_{Hi}$, $x^0(\alpha) = x^*(u^*(J))$, which is an analytic family of equilibria by Theorem 1. By Theorem 2(b) the Jacobian at $\alpha = 0$ has a simple pair $\pm i\omega_i$, $n_s = 2$ and $n_u = 0$; the pair continues analytically as $\mu(\alpha) \pm i\omega(\alpha)$ with $\mu'(0) = \text{Re } \lambda'(J_{Hi}) \neq 0$ by (d), and $\ell_1(0) \neq 0$ by (e). Theorem 4.5 applies with $\sigma = +1$ at $H1$ and $\sigma = -1$ at $H2$. The topological equivalence of the families maps equilibria to equilibria, preserves their asymptotic stability, maps periodic orbits to periodic orbits, and preserves orbital asymptotic stability and its failure, since these are defined through neighbourhoods and limits along orbits. At $H1$ the equilibrium is asymptotically stable exactly for $J < J_{H1}$ near J_{H1} (Theorem 2(a)), and in the normal form with $\sigma = +1$ exactly for $\beta < 0$; so these parameter sets correspond, and the unstable cycle of the normal form for $\beta < 0$ gives (a); the suspension by $\dot{y}^s = -y^s$ keeps it not orbitally stable. At $H2$ the equilibrium is unstable exactly for $J < J_{H2}$ near J_{H2} and, with $\sigma = -1$, the origin exactly for $\beta > 0$; the stable cycle there, attracting also in the y^s directions, gives (b). $\square$

5 Validated integration and Poincaré maps

This section states and proves what the program `code/certify_bistability.py` relies on; the implementation is `code/hh_lohner.py` (integrator and Poincaré maps), `code/certlib.py` (Krawczyk, Gershgorin, the equilibrium) and `code/ball_stable.py` (the contraction on the E_l interval), with the model in `code/hh_arb.py`. The program extends (1) by E_l as a fifth variable with $\dot{E}_l = 0$, so that an interval of E_l is a direction of the initial set. We write F for this analytic vector field on $\mathbb{R}^5$, φ_t for its flow, and, for $y \in \mathbb{R}^5$,

$$x_k(y) = \frac{1}{k!} \frac{d^k}{dt^k} \varphi_t(y) \Big|_{t=0}, \quad A_k(y) = \frac{1}{k!} \frac{d^k}{dt^k} D\varphi_t(y) \Big|_{t=0} = Dx_k(y).$$

The x_k follow from the recursion $x_{k+1} = [F(x(\cdot))]_k / (k+1)$, $[\cdot]_k$ the k -th Taylor coefficient in t , and the A_k from $A_0 = I$, $A_{k+1} = \frac{1}{k+1} \sum_{i \leq k} [DF(x(\cdot))]_i A_{k-i}$ (the variational equation $\dot{V} = DF(x(t))V$). The program evaluates both recursions in ball arithmetic on a box X , with the Taylor coefficients of the rate functions from exact formulas for the exponentials, from Lemma 4.4(b) for Ψ , and from the reciprocal series of $1 + e^{(30-u)/10} e^{-(u-u_0)/10}$ for β_h . By the inclusion property of ball arithmetic this gives boxes $x_k(X) \ni x_k(y)$ and $A_k(X) \ni A_k(y)$ for all $y \in X$. For intervals we write $[0, h]^k = [0, h]^k$.

5.1 One step

Lemma 5.1 (proved; the a priori enclosure). *Let X and Y be boxes, $h > 0$, $p \geq 1$, and suppose $\sum_{k \leq p} x_k(X)[0, h]^k + x_{p+1}(Y)[0, h]^{p+1} \subset \text{int } Y$. Then for every $y \in X$ the solution $\varphi_s(y)$ exists and lies in Y for $s \in [0, h]$, and $\varphi_s(y) \in \sum_{k \leq p} x_k(y)s^k + x_{p+1}(Y)s^{p+1}$.*

Proof. The left side contains X (the term $k = 0$ is X and the others contain 0), so $X \subset \text{int } Y$. Let $y \in X$ and $s_1 = \sup\{s \in [0, h] : \varphi_\sigma(y) \in Y \text{ for } \sigma \in [0, s]\}$. For $s \leq s_1$ Taylor's theorem with the Lagrange remainder, applied to each component of the analytic function $t \mapsto \varphi_t(y)$, gives $\varphi_s(y)_i = \sum_{k \leq p} x_k(y)_i s^k + x_{p+1}(\varphi_\xi(y))_i s^{p+1}$ for some $\xi \in (0, s)$, because $\frac{1}{(p+1)!} \frac{d^{p+1}}{dt^{p+1}} \varphi_t(y) \Big|_{t=\xi} = x_{p+1}(\varphi_\xi(y))$ by the group property. Since $\varphi_\xi(y) \in Y$, $\varphi_s(y)$ lies in the left side of the hypothesis, hence in $\text{int } Y$. If $s_1 < h$, the solution would stay in Y a little beyond s_1 (it is in the open set $\text{int } Y$ at s_1), a contradiction; so $s_1 = h$ and the solution, which stays in a compact set, exists on $[0, h]$. $\square$

Lemma 5.2 (proved; the variational enclosure). *With X, Y, h, p as in Lemma 5.1, let W be a box of 5×5 matrices with $\sum_{k \leq p} A_k(X)[0, h]^k + A_{p+1}(Y)W[0, h]^{p+1} \subset \text{int } W$ entrywise. Then $D\varphi_s(y) \in W$ and $D\varphi_s(y) \in N(s) := \sum_{k \leq p} A_k(X)s^k + A_{p+1}(Y)W s^{p+1}$ for $y \in X, s \in [0, h]$.*

Proof. Differentiating $D\varphi_{s+\sigma}(y) = D\varphi_\sigma(\varphi_s(y))D\varphi_s(y)$ k times in σ at $\sigma = 0$ gives

$$\frac{1}{k!} \frac{d^k}{ds^k} D\varphi_s(y) = A_k(\varphi_s(y)) D\varphi_s(y).$$

The argument of Lemma 5.1, entrywise, with $\varphi_\xi(y) \in Y$ from that lemma and $D\varphi_\xi(y) \in W$ up to s_1 , proves the claim; $D\varphi_0 = I$ lies in the left side, hence in $\text{int } W$. $\square$

Lemma 5.3 (proved; the mean-value form). *With X convex, $\bar{y} \in X$ and the hypotheses of Lemma 5.1, for every $y \in X$ and $s \in [0, h]$ there is a matrix $\tilde{M}$ in $M(s) := \sum_{k \leq p} A_k(X)s^k$ such that $\varphi_s(y) - \sum_{k \leq p} x_k(\bar{y})s^k - \tilde{M}(y - \bar{y}) \in x_{p+1}(Y)s^{p+1}$.*

Proof. $T(y) = \sum_{k \leq p} x_k(y)s^k$ has $DT(y) = \sum_{k \leq p} A_k(y)s^k$. By the mean value theorem on the segment from $\bar{y}$ to y , $T_i(y) - T_i(\bar{y}) = DT_i(\zeta_i)(y - \bar{y})$ with $\zeta_i \in X$, and the row $DT_i(\zeta_i)$ lies in row i of $M(s)$. Lemma 5.1 bounds $\varphi_s(y) - T(y)$. $\square$

Sets. The program represents a set of initial points as $S = \{\bar{x} + C\rho_0 + B\rho : \rho_0 \in r_0, \rho \in r\}$ with an exact point $\bar{x}$, exact matrices C, B and boxes r_0, r (the doubleton sets of Zgliczyński [31], after Lohner [23]), and a set of matrices as $\{\bar{V} + B_V R : R \in R_V\}$. One step to time s , with $X \supset S$ and $\tilde{M}$ as in Lemma 5.3, computes: $a = \sum_{k \leq p} x_k(\bar{x})s^k + x_{p+1}(Y)s^{p+1}$, $\bar{M}$ = the midpoint of $M(s)$, $C' =$ the midpoint of $\bar{M}C$, $Z = a + (M(s) - \bar{M})(Cr_0 + Br) + (\bar{M}C - C')r_0$, $\bar{x}' =$ the midpoint of Z , a matrix B' from a floating-point QR decomposition, a ball enclosure of B'^{-1} , and $r' = (B'^{-1}\bar{M}B)r + B'^{-1}(Z - \bar{x}')$.

Lemma 5.4 (proved). *If $y = \bar{x} + C\rho_0 + B\rho \in S$, then $\varphi_s(y) = \bar{x}' + C'\rho_0 + B'\rho'$ for some $\rho' \in r'$. The same holds for the matrix sets: if $D\varphi_t(x_0) = \bar{V} + B_V R$, $R \in R_V$, and $D\varphi_s(\varphi_t(x_0)) \in N(s)$, the program's update gives $D\varphi_{t+s}(x_0) = \bar{V}' + B'_V R'$ with $R' \in R'_V$.*

Proof. By Lemma 5.3, $\varphi_s(y) = \alpha + \tilde{M}(C\rho_0 + B\rho)$ with $\alpha \in a$ and $\tilde{M} \in M(s)$. Then $\varphi_s(y) = \zeta + C'\rho_0 + \bar{M}B\rho$ with $\zeta = \alpha + (\tilde{M} - \bar{M})(C\rho_0 + B\rho) + (\bar{M}C - C')\rho_0 \in Z$, and $\varphi_s(y) = \bar{x}' + C'\rho_0 + B'\rho'$ with $\rho' = B'^{-1}\bar{M}B\rho + B'^{-1}(\zeta - \bar{x}') \in r'$, all inclusions being those of ball arithmetic. For matrices, $\tilde{N}(\bar{V} + B_V R) = \tilde{N}\bar{V} + (\tilde{N} - \bar{N})(\bar{V} + B_V R) + \bar{N}B_V R$ with $\tilde{N} \in N(s)$ and $\bar{N}$ its midpoint, and the same rearrangement applies. $\square$

5.2 Crossing a section

Let $\Sigma = \{x_i = c\}$ and $g(x) = x_i - c$ (the sections here are crossed with $\dot{x}_i > 0$). The Poincaré routine (`code/hh_lohner.py`, `poincare`) starts from a set S_0 whose hull lies exactly on Σ (otherwise it stops: `check_on_section`), and integrates step by step, classifying every step by the a priori box Y of the step, an enclosure $F_i(Y)$ of $\dot{x}_i$ on Y , and the hull X of the set at the start of the step:

- (D) *departure*: while the hull meets Σ , every step must have $F_i > 0$ on Y ;
- (N) *no crossing*: $g \neq 0$ on Y ; or $F_i > 0$ on Y and $g > 0$ on X ; or $F_i > 0$ on Y and $g < 0$ on the hulls at both ends of the step;
- (P) *pass*: $F_i < 0$ on Y (counted as a downward pass);
- (H) *hit*: $F_i > 0$ on Y , $g < 0$ on X , and times $0 \leq s_- < s_+ \leq h$ with $g < 0$ on the enclosure of the set at time s_- and $g > 0$ at time s_+ .

Lemma 5.5 (proved; first hit and the crossing). *Suppose a run from $S_0 \subset \Sigma$ consists of steps of types (D), (N), (P) followed by one step of type (H) that ends at the total time $t_0 + s_+$. For $y \in S_0$ let $\tau(y)$ be the smallest $t > 0$ with $g(\varphi_t(y)) = 0$ and $\frac{d}{dt}g(\varphi_t(y)) > 0$. Then $\tau(y)$ exists and lies in $t_0 + (s_-, s_+)$, every $t \in (0, \tau(y))$ with $g(\varphi_t(y)) = 0$ has $\frac{d}{dt}g(\varphi_t(y)) < 0$, and there are at most as many such t as steps of type (P). Moreover, with $Y_T \supset \varphi_{[t_0+s_-, t_0+s_+]}(S_0)$ and any $s_m \in [s_-, s_+]$, the point $P(y) = \varphi_{\tau(y)}(y)$ satisfies, for each j ,*

$$P_j(y) = \varphi_{t_0+s_m}(y)_j - q_j(\varphi_{t_0+s_m}(y)_i - c), \quad \tau(y) = t_0 + s_m - \frac{\varphi_{t_0+s_m}(y)_i - c}{\bar{F}_i},$$

with q_j in the interval of values of F_j/F_i on Y_T and $\bar{F}_i$ in the interval of values of F_i on Y_T .

Proof. On a step with $F_i > 0$ on Y the function $t \mapsto g(\varphi_t(y))$ is strictly increasing, and on a step with $F_i < 0$ strictly decreasing, since $\frac{d}{dt}g(\varphi_t(y)) = F_i(\varphi_t(y))$ and $\varphi_t(y) \in Y$ (Lemma 5.1). In the departure phase $g(\varphi_0(y)) = 0$ and g increases, so $g > 0$ for $t > 0$ until the hull leaves Σ . A step of type (N) has no zero of g : either $g \neq 0$ on Y , or g increases from a positive value, or g increases

and is negative at both ends. A step of type (P) has at most one zero, with negative derivative. On the step of type (H), g is negative at the start and increasing, negative at s_- and positive at s_+ , so it has exactly one zero, in (s_-, s_+) , with positive derivative. This proves the first part. For the formulas, $\varphi_\tau(y)_j - \varphi_{t_0+s_m}(y)_j = \int F_j dt$ and $c - \varphi_{t_0+s_m}(y)_i = \int F_i dt$ over the arc between the two times, which lies in Y_T ; since $F_i > 0$ on Y_T , the first integral is $\int (F_j/F_i) F_i dt$, a weighted mean of F_j/F_i times the second, and the second is the length of the time interval times a mean of F_i . $\square$

The program evaluates these formulas on the Lohner representation of $\varphi_{t_0+s_m}(S_0)$ (Lemma 5.4), so that the time shift and the displacement along the flow cancel to first order, intersects the result with Y_T , and records the extremes of u over the step enclosures; the “ u reaches at least” bounds of the theorems are maxima over step times of lower bounds of u on the set, so every orbit from S_0 attains them.

Lemma 5.6 (proved; the derivative). *Under the hypotheses of Lemma 5.5, τ and P are analytic on a neighbourhood of S_0 in Σ , and $DP(y) = (I - F(P(y))e_i^T/F_i(P(y)))D\varphi_{\tau(y)}(y)$ on the tangent space of Σ . If $D\varphi_{t_0}(y) \in \bar{V} + B_V R_V$ and $N(T)$ is the enclosure of Lemma 5.2 over $T = [s_-, s_+]$, then $DP(y)$ lies in $(I - F(\mathcal{P})e_i^T/F_i(\mathcal{P}))N(T)(\bar{V} + B_V R_V)$, where $\mathcal{P}$ is the enclosure of $P(S_0)$.*

Proof. $G(t, y) = g(\varphi_t(y))$ has $\partial_t G(\tau(y), y) = F_i(P(y)) > 0$, so the implicit function theorem gives an analytic τ with $D\tau = -e_i^T D\varphi_\tau/F_i(P)$, and $DP = D\varphi_\tau + F(P)D\tau$. The enclosure follows from $D\varphi_\tau(y) = D\varphi_{\tau-t_0}(\varphi_{t_0}(y))D\varphi_{t_0}(y)$ and Lemmas 5.2 and 5.4. $\square$

In the coordinates (m, n, h) of Σ_{20} or Σ_5 and for fixed E_l (recall $\dot{E}_l = 0$), the matrix of DP is the block of rows and columns m, n, h of the 5×5 matrix of the lemma; its row u vanishes.

Lemma 5.7 (proved; minimal period). *Under the hypotheses of Lemma 5.5, if $y \in S_0$ and $P(y) = y$, the orbit of y is periodic with minimal period $\tau(y)$.*

Proof. $\varphi_{\tau(y)}(y) = y$, and y is not an equilibrium because $F_i(y) > 0$ (departure condition). The periods of a nonconstant periodic orbit are the integer multiples of its minimal period T_0 . If $T_0 < \tau(y)$, then $\varphi_{T_0}(y) = y \in \Sigma$ with $\frac{d}{dt}g = F_i(y) > 0$ at $t = T_0 \in (0, \tau(y))$, which Lemma 5.5 excludes. $\square$

Lemma 5.8 (proved; Floquet multipliers). *Let Γ be a periodic orbit with minimal period T through $y \in \Sigma$, $F_i(y) \neq 0$, and $M = D\varphi_T(y)$. Then $\det(\lambda I - M) = (\lambda - 1)\det(\lambda I - DP(y))$, $DP(y)$ acting on the tangent space $E = \{v : v_i = 0\}$ of Σ .*

Proof. $MF(y) = F(y)$, and $F(y) \notin E$. With $\Pi = I - F(y)e_i^T/F_i(y)$, the projection onto E along $F(y)$, $DP(y) = \Pi M|_E$ by Lemma 5.6 (here $P(y) = y$). For $v \in E$, $Mv = \Pi Mv + \frac{e_i^T Mv}{F_i(y)} F(y)$, so in a basis consisting of $F(y)$ and a basis of E the matrix of M is block upper triangular with diagonal blocks 1 and $DP(y)$. $\square$

5.3 Fixed points, multipliers and stability

Theorem 5.9 (cited: Krawczyk [20], Moore [25], in the form of Rump [27, Theorem 13.3]). *Let $G : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ be C^1 , $\tilde{z} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, X a box with $0 \in X$, R a real $n \times n$ matrix and $\mathbf{M}$ an interval matrix that contains $DG(z)$ for every $z \in \tilde{z} + X$. If $-RG(\tilde{z}) + (I - R\mathbf{M})X \subset \text{int } X$, then R and every matrix in $\mathbf{M}$ are nonsingular and G has exactly one zero in $\tilde{z} + X$.*

The program (`code/certlib.py`, `krawczyk`) applies it to $G = P - \text{id}$ on a box $Z = \bar{z} + X$ of Σ , with R the floating-point inverse of the midpoint of $\mathbf{M} - I$; it computes $K = \bar{z} - R(\mathcal{P}(\bar{z}) - \bar{z}) + (I - R(\mathbf{DP}(Z) - I))X$ with an enclosure $\mathcal{P}(\bar{z})$ of $P(\bar{z})$ and an enclosure $\mathbf{DP}(Z)$ of DP over Z , and checks $K \subset \text{int } Z$, which implies the hypothesis.

Lemma 5.10 (proved; Gershgorin discs). *Let $\mathbf{M}$ be a real interval matrix, S an invertible complex matrix, and $D_i = \{z : |z - c_i| \leq R_i\}$ discs with $R_i \geq |(S^{-1}MS)_{ii} - c_i| + \sum_{j \neq i} |(S^{-1}MS)_{ij}|$ for every $M \in \mathbf{M}$. Then for every $M \in \mathbf{M}$: (a) every eigenvalue lies in $\bigcup_i D_i$; (b) a union of k discs that is disjoint from the other discs contains exactly k eigenvalues, counted with multiplicity; (c) if D_1 is disjoint from the others and c_1 is real, the eigenvalue in D_1 is real.*

Proof. (a) Gershgorin's theorem [10] for $S^{-1}MS$, whose discs lie in the D_i : if $S^{-1}MSv = \lambda v$ and $|v_i|$ is maximal, $|\lambda - (S^{-1}MS)_{ii}| \leq \sum_{j \neq i} |(S^{-1}MS)_{ij}|$. (b) Let Δ be the diagonal of $S^{-1}MS$ and $M_t = \Delta + t(S^{-1}MS - \Delta)$, $t \in [0, 1]$. The Gershgorin discs of M_t have the same centres and t times the radii, so they lie in the D_i , and by (a) no eigenvalue of M_t crosses the boundary of the union of the k discs. The eigenvalues depend continuously on t ; at $t = 0$ they are the centres, and exactly k of them lie in the union. (c) M is real, so $\bar{\lambda}$ is an eigenvalue with $\bar{\lambda} \in D_1$ when $\lambda \in D_1$; by (b) D_1 contains only one eigenvalue, so $\lambda = \bar{\lambda}$. $\square$

The program takes S from the floating-point eigenvectors of the midpoint of $\mathbf{M}$, encloses S^{-1} and $S^{-1}\mathbf{M}S$ in ball arithmetic, and for a real eigenvalue of the midpoint takes a real eigenvector, so that c_1 is real (`code/certlib.py`, `gershgorin_eigenbasis` and `multiplier_test`).

Lemma 5.11 (proved; contraction). *Let $Z \subset \mathbb{R}^3$ be a box, $P : Z \rightarrow \text{int } Z$ of class C^1 with $\|DP(z)\|_\infty \leq \kappa < 1$ for $z \in Z$. Then P has exactly one fixed point z^* in Z , $P^k(z) \rightarrow z^*$ for $z \in Z$, and every eigenvalue of $DP(z^*)$ has modulus at most κ .*

Proof. Z is convex, so $\|P(z) - P(z')\|_\infty \leq \kappa\|z - z'\|_\infty$ by the mean value inequality, and Banach's fixed point theorem applies on the complete set Z . The spectral radius is at most any induced norm. $\square$

Lemma 5.12 (proved; orbital asymptotic stability). *Let Γ be a periodic orbit with minimal period T through $y^* \in \Sigma$, $F_i(y^*) > 0$, and suppose every eigenvalue of $DP(y^*)$ has modulus less than 1. Then Γ is orbitally asymptotically stable.*

Proof. Step 1. There is a norm $|\cdot|_*$ on the tangent space of Σ with $|DP(y^*)|_* < 1$ (for a matrix of spectral radius ρ and any $\varepsilon > 0$ there is an induced norm with value less than $\rho + \varepsilon$). By continuity of DP and the mean value inequality there are $\kappa < 1$ and $\delta_0 > 0$ such that $B_0 = \{z \in \Sigma : |z - y^*|_* \leq \delta_0\}$ is mapped into itself and $|P(z) - y^*|_* \leq \kappa|z - y^*|_*$ there. Shrinking δ_0 , the hitting time τ is continuous on B_0 with values in $[T/2, 2T]$ (Lemma 5.6).

Step 2. Everything is at fixed E_l , in $\mathbb{R}^4$. By the implicit function theorem applied to $g(\varphi_t(x)) = 0$ at $(t, x) = (0, y^*)$, there are a neighbourhood U of y^* and a continuous t_U on U with $t_U(y^*) = 0$, $|t_U| \leq T/4$ and $\pi(x) = \varphi_{t_U(x)}(x) \in \Sigma$; π is continuous and $\pi(y^*) = y^*$. Given $\eta > 0$ and $\varepsilon > 0$, let $U_\eta \subset U$ be a neighbourhood of y^* with $\pi(U_\eta) \subset B_\eta = \{z \in \Sigma : |z - y^*|_* \leq \eta\}$. The map $(t, x) \mapsto \varphi_t(x)$ is uniformly continuous on $[0, 3T] \times \{x : \text{dist}(x, \Gamma) \leq \delta_1\}$ for a small $\delta_1 > 0$, so there is $\delta \in (0, \delta_1]$ such that $|x - \gamma| < \delta$, $\gamma \in \Gamma$, implies $|\varphi_t(x) - \varphi_t(\gamma)| < \varepsilon$ for $t \in [0, 3T]$ and $\varphi_{2T-s}(x) \in U_\eta$, where $\gamma = \varphi_s(y^*)$, $s \in [0, T]$ (because $\varphi_{2T-s}(\gamma) = y^*$). Such an x stays within ε of Γ up to the time $2T - s + t_U(\varphi_{2T-s}(x)) \in [3T/4, 9T/4]$, at which it lies in B_η .

Step 3. Continuous dependence on initial data on $[0, 2T]$ gives L with $|\varphi_t(z) - \varphi_t(y^*)| \leq L|z - y^*|_*$ for $z \in B_0$, $t \in [0, 2T]$. For $z \in B_\eta$, $\eta \leq \delta_0$, the iterates $P^k(z)$ stay in B_η and tend to y^* , the

hitting times lie in $[T/2, 2T]$, and between the k -th and the next hit the orbit stays within $L|P^k(z) - y^*|_* \leq L\kappa^k\eta$ of Γ . Given ε , choose $\eta \leq \delta_0$ with $L\eta < \varepsilon$ and then δ as in Step 2: every x with $\text{dist}(x, \Gamma) < \delta$ stays within ε of Γ for all $t \geq 0$, and its distance to Γ tends to 0. $\square$

Lemma 5.13 (proved; saddle type). *Under the hypotheses of Lemma 5.12, except that $DP(y^*)$ has a simple real eigenvalue $\mu_1 > 1$ and its other eigenvalues have modulus less than 1, Γ is not orbitally stable.*

Proof. Choose coordinates $w = (\xi, \zeta) \in \mathbb{R} \times \mathbb{R}^2$ on Σ centred at y^* in which $DP(y^*) = \text{diag}(\mu_1, B)$, and a norm $|\cdot|$ on $\mathbb{R}^2$ with $|B| \leq \beta < 1$. Fix $\varepsilon > 0$ with $\beta + \varepsilon \leq \mu_1 - \varepsilon$ and $\mu_1 - \varepsilon > 1$, and $\delta_0 > 0$ such that $P(w) = DP(y^*)w + r(w)$ with $\|r(w)\| \leq \varepsilon\|w\|$ for $\|w\| = \max(|\xi|, |\zeta|) \leq \delta_0$. On the cone $\mathcal{K} = \{|\zeta| \leq |\xi|\}$, $w' = P(w)$ satisfies $|\xi'| \geq (\mu_1 - \varepsilon)|\xi|$ and $|\zeta'| \leq \beta|\zeta| + \varepsilon|\xi| \leq |\xi'|$, so $w' \in \mathcal{K}$ and $\|w'\| \geq (\mu_1 - \varepsilon)\|w\|$. Hence every $w \in \mathcal{K} \setminus \{0\}$, however close to 0, has an iterate with $\|P^k(w)\| > \delta_0$ whose predecessor has norm at most δ_0 ; by continuity of P , $\|P^k(w)\| \leq \Lambda\delta_0$ for a constant Λ . Transversality gives $c_0 > 0$ and $\eta_0 > 0$ with $\text{dist}(z, \Gamma) \geq c_0\|z\|$ for $z \in \Sigma$ with $\|z\| \leq \eta_0$: for $|s| \leq s_0$ small, the point $\varphi_s(y^*)$ of Γ satisfies $|z - \varphi_s(y^*)| \geq |x_i(\varphi_s(y^*)) - c| \geq a|s|$ with $a = \frac{1}{2}F_i(y^*)$, and $|z - \varphi_s(y^*)| \geq |z - y^*| - b|s|$ with $b = \max |F|$ near Γ , so $|z - \varphi_s(y^*)| \geq \frac{a}{a+b}|z - y^*|$; the rest of Γ is at a positive distance from y^* , hence from z when z is close to y^* ; and the norms are equivalent. Choosing δ_0 with $\Lambda\delta_0 \leq \eta_0$, orbits that start arbitrarily close to Γ reach the distance $c_0\delta_0$ from it, and Γ is not orbitally stable. $\square$

6 Proofs of Theorems 4 and 5 and Corollary 6

The references are to `data/certify_bistability.txt`; the program works at 96 bits with Taylor order $p = 20$ and a remainder tolerance $1 \cdot 10^{-18}$ relative to the scales $(100, 1, 1, 1, 10)$ of (u, m, n, h, E_l) . Every decimal bound it prints in stages 3 to 7 is rounded outward from its ball, and all 333 of them are read back as exact rationals and compared with the balls (stage 7, first check). Theorems 4 and 5 are the program's Theorems C and B; its Theorem A appears in the proof of Corollary 6.

Proof of Theorem 5. Fix E_l as in the theorem; for E_l^* the program uses a ball of radius below 10^{-25} that contains it (stage 3), and every statement holds for each E_l in that ball. (a) The program computes a candidate $\bar{z}$ on Σ_{20} by floating-point Newton steps, integrates the thin set $\{\bar{z}\} \times \{E_l\}$ to its first return (a C^0 run) and the box $Z = \bar{z} + X$ of radius about $1.21 \cdot 10^{-15}$ (C^1 run over Z ; the radius is that at $E_l = 10.613$), each by a chain of steps as in Lemma 5.5. It obtains enclosures of $P(\bar{z})$ and of DP over Z (Lemma 5.6), the latter with entries of radius at most $1.10 \cdot 10^{-9}$, and verifies $K \subset \text{int } Z$ (stage 4, “Krawczyk: unique fixed point of the first-return map in Z ”). By Theorem 5.9, P has exactly one fixed point z^* in Z ; by Lemma 5.7 its orbit Γ_s is periodic with minimal period $\tau(z^*)$, which lies in the enclosure of τ over Z (Table 1). The Gershgorin discs of $\mathbf{DP}(Z)$ (Lemma 5.10) all lie in the open unit disc (“all nontrivial Floquet multipliers of the stable orbit lie in $|\mu| < 1$ ”), and the first is disjoint from the other two (“multiplier discs ... are isolated”), so it contains exactly one multiplier μ_1 and the other two lie in the union of the others; Lemma 5.8 identifies these eigenvalues with the nontrivial multipliers, and Lemma 5.12 gives orbital asymptotic stability. The run passes Σ_{20} downward once and certifies the first return in 303 steps; its step enclosures show that every orbit from Z reaches $u \geq 95.953532$ (and the corresponding values at the other E_l).

(b) The same on Σ_5 , with a box of radius about $2.13 \cdot 10^{-14}$: Krawczyk gives the fixed point and the period; the three discs are pairwise disjoint, the first is centred on the positive real axis and lies outside the closed unit disc, and the other two lie inside the open unit disc (“exactly one Floquet

multiplier of the second orbit is real and > 1). By Lemma 5.10(b), (c), μ_1 is real and larger than 1, and Γ_u is of saddle type; Lemma 5.13 shows that it is not orbitally stable. The step enclosures bound $u \leq 11.045813$ along every orbit from the box.

(c) Γ_s reaches $u \geq 95.953532$ and Γ_u stays below 11.045813 (at $E_l = 10.613$; similarly at the other values), so they are different (“the orbits are distinct”); neither is an equilibrium, because $\dot{u} > 0$ at their section points. Table 3 lists outward roundings of the Krawczyk boxes K , which contain the fixed points. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 4. Stage 4b cuts $[10.59, 10.62]$ into 60 intervals of width $5 \cdot 10^{-4}$ and checks that they cover it without gaps (“the pieces cover $[10.59, 10.62]$ ”). For each piece $\mathcal{E}$ it chooses a box Z on Σ_{20} , of radius about $4.6 \cdot 10^{-7}$ around an approximate fixed point, and runs two first-return computations over $Z \times \mathcal{E}$ as in Lemma 5.5: a C^0 run that shows $P_E(Z) \subset \text{int } Z$ for every $E \in \mathcal{E}$, and a C^1 run that bounds $\|DP_E(z)\|_\infty$ for all $(z, E) \in Z \times \mathcal{E}$, by the maximum over the rows of the sums of the moduli of the entries of the enclosure. Every piece passes with a bound between 0.5413 and 0.5446 (“every piece: $P_E(Z)$ in $\text{int } Z$ and $\sup \|DP_E\|_\infty < 1$ ”). By Lemma 5.11, P_E has exactly one fixed point in Z , and every eigenvalue of DP_E there has modulus at most 0.5446; by Lemma 5.7 its orbit is periodic with minimal period in the enclosure of τ over $Z \times \mathcal{E}$, and by Lemma 5.12 it is orbitally asymptotically stable. The union over the pieces of the period enclosures is $[16.005827509, 16.013912063]$, and the minimum over the pieces of the lower bounds of the maximum of u is 95.953 (stage 4b, last line, and stage 7). $\square$

Proof of Corollary 6. By Theorem 2(c), $J_{H1} \geq 9.773337 > 8$ for every $E_l \in [10.59, 10.62]$ (`data/certify_equilibria_hopf.txt`, part D), so by Theorems 1 and 2(a) the equilibrium at $J = 8$ is unique and locally asymptotically stable. Theorem 4 gives the orbitally asymptotically stable periodic orbit, Theorem 5(b) the orbit of saddle type at the three values, and Lemma 2.2 the equivalent statement in J . The program for Theorems 4 and 5 proves the equilibrium part again, independently, at 96 bits with the other implementation of Ψ (its Theorem A, stage 3): an interval Newton step on $J_{ss}(u) - 8$ over $U = [4.64089, 4.65911]$ with $J'_{ss}(U) \subset [2.3706, 2.4294]$ maps U into its interior; $J'_{ss} > 0$ on $W = [3.646624, 5.646624]$ (64 pieces); $J_{ss} - 8$ has no zero on $[-12, 115] \setminus W$ (70 interval evaluations) and none outside $[-12, 115]$ (the signs of Lemma 2.1); the equilibrium lies in the box $u \in [4.64375, 4.65625]$, $m \in [0.0900353, 0.0901647]$, $n \in [0.3905195, 0.3906805]$, $h \in [0.42941, 0.43059]$; the enclosed characteristic polynomial has $a_1 \in [4.8848, 4.8952]$, $a_2 \in [1.2753, 1.3247]$, $a_3 \in [1.5908, 1.6092]$, $a_4 \in [0.1929, 0.2071]$, $D_2 \in [4.616, 4.784]$ and $D_3 \in [2.406, 3.594]$; and four pairwise disjoint Gershgorin discs, centred at -4.690211 , $-0.034513 \pm 0.566815i$ and -0.135017 with radii $6.9 \cdot 10^{-3}$, $8.4 \cdot 10^{-3}$ and $6.1 \cdot 10^{-5}$, lie in $\text{Re } \lambda < 0$. $\square$

7 The computer-assisted method

Ball arithmetic. All rigorous computations use Arb [18] through python-flint 0.9.0 (FLINT 3.6.0), in which a real number is a ball $[m \pm r]$ and a complex number a pair of balls. Every operation returns a ball that contains all results for all inputs in the input balls, and a comparison is true only if it holds for all points of the balls; an undecided comparison is false. The constants of (1) are exact rationals, converted to balls. Floating point (numpy, scipy, mpmath) proposes candidates, subdivision points, step sizes, the frames B of the Lohner sets, the Krawczyk preconditioner and the eigenvector matrices of the Gershgorin discs; a bad choice can make a check fail but not succeed wrongly. The programs print every check and stop at the first failure (`code/certify_bistability.py`) or exit with an error after reporting all of them (`code/certify_equilibria_hopf.py`).

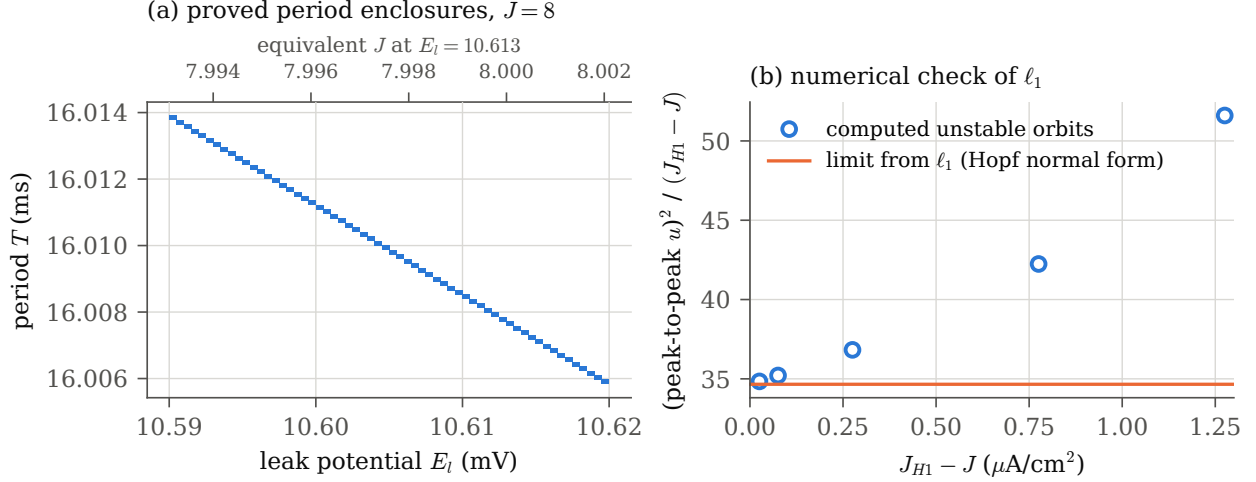


Figure 3: (a) Theorem 4: the proved enclosures of the period of $\Gamma(E_l)$ on each of the 60 pieces of the E_l interval; the top axis gives the equivalent current at $E_l = 10.613$ (Lemma 2.2). (b) Numerical: (peak-to-peak amplitude of u)²/($J_{H1} - J$) for the unstable periodic orbits computed in floating point at $J = 8.5$ to 9.75 ($E_l = 10.613$; Table 5), and its limit $16|q_u|^2 \operatorname{Re} \lambda'(J_{H1})/(\omega_1 \ell_1) \in [34.657379, 34.657380]$ predicted by the Hopf normal form from the proved values of Theorem 2 (Section 8).

Table 4: The checks of the two programs by kind, from their outputs.

program	all	proof	consistency	controls	self-tests	cross-checks	numerical
<code>certify_equilibria_hopf.py</code>	38	17	6	5	8	2	–
<code>certify_bistability.py</code>	84	30	–	24	23	–	7

Printed bounds. A bound printed as an interval $[a, b]$, or after $\leq$ or $\geq$, is rounded outward from its ball in exact rational arithmetic (`code/outward.py`), and each program re-reads all of its printed bounds as rationals and compares them with the balls (99 and 333 bounds). A ball printed as $[m \pm r]$ is Arb’s own decimal enclosure. `code/make_numbers.py` copies these bounds into the manuscript, or rounds them outward further, in exact rational arithmetic; no number of a theorem is typed by hand.

Checks. Each program counts its checks by kind (Table 4). A *proof* check is a step of a proof above. A *consistency* check verifies that an identity which a lemma proves exactly (such as $Aq = i\omega q$) holds within the enclosures. A *negative control* feeds a deliberately wrong input to the code of a certificate, which must refuse it: for example, the Hopf factorization test at $u_{H1} + 10^{-3}$, where $a_2 - \omega^2 - a_4/\omega^2 \in [-0.0004982, -0.0004981]$; mutated versions of (3); Krawczyk on boxes shifted by ten box radii or by 10^{-9} , and on the stable orbit’s box with the vector field at $J = 8.05$ (the centre of K lies $4.5 \cdot 10^{10}$ box radii away); an initial set on $u = 20$ with the crossing detected on $u = 19.999$; the equilibrium test at $J = 20$, where $D_3 \in [-18.86, -17.14]$; the contraction test on a box too small to contain the fixed points, and on the saddle orbit, where every member of the enclosure has $\|DP\|_\infty \geq 37.997$; the integrator with the Taylor remainder set to 0, and the a priori test on boxes that do not contain the motion; and wrong vector fields, among them $g_{Na} = 120.0001$ against a high-precision reference solution. A *self-test* compares the code with a known answer (exact solutions of test equations, the Poincaré map of a planar system with known multipliers, mpmath references for the Hodgkin–Huxley flow in three regimes, the test systems for ℓ_1). *Cross-checks* and *numerical-only* checks are non-rigorous and enter no proof.

What an end-to-end run cannot show. A certificate can pass although a rigorous ingredient is missing, when the true solution satisfies the inequalities with a wide margin. An independent reading of `code/certify_bistability.py` within the project (2026-09-26) checked the model against the 1952 equations and made 13 deliberate mutations of the code, of which 10 first passed unnoticed; it also found that printed bounds were rounded to nearest rather than outward and that a Poincaré map could be started off its section. The program was changed so that all 13 mutations now stop it (the outward printing, the section check and the controls that run the certificate code described above). The mutation list and its harness are not in this folder, and the changes have not been read again. `code/certify_equilibria_hopf.py` has had no mutation study; its tests of (3) and its controls were added for this paper.

Trust base. The proofs assume that Arb and python-flint compute correct enclosures for the operations used (field operations, `exp`, `hypgeom_1f1`, matrix products, `inv`, `solve` and `charpoly`), that Python’s integers and fractions are exact, and that the programs do what Sections 4 to 6 describe.

8 Numerical observations

Nothing in this section is used in a proof. The numbers are from stage 2 (floating point, `scipy DOP853` at relative tolerance 10^{-12} ; `mpmath`) and stage 6 (a Taylor code at 160 bits without error control) of `data/certify_bistability.txt`.

- *Rest and the equilibrium branch.* At $J = 0$ and $E_l = 10.613$ the equilibrium is at $u \approx 3.620669 \cdot 10^{-3}$ mV, not at 0 (Proposition 2.3). J_{ss} is increasing on a grid of $[-12, 250]$ with $J_{ss}(250) \approx 9418.0$, so numerically the equilibrium is unique for J well beyond 200.
- *The fold of cycles.* Along the branch of stable periodic orbits parametrized by the period, a multiplier crosses 1 at $J_{LPC} \approx 6.260321$ ($E_l = 10.613$) and 6.264545 ($E_l = E_l^*$), with period ≈ 19.8952 ms, so repetitive firing starts at about 50.3 Hz; the difference of the two currents is $0.3(10.613 - E_l^*)$, as Lemma 2.2 requires. Numerically the equilibrium and firing coexist for $J \in (J_{LPC}, J_{H1})$. This range is not simple: continuation of the orbits born at J_{H1} finds folds and period doublings near $J \approx 7.85$ to 7.92 ($E_l = E_l^*$; `work/chaos/REPORT.md` in the folder of this paper), close to where Guckenheimer and Oliva found chaos [12], which we do not study here. The current $J = 8$ of Theorems 4 and 5 lies above these values.
- *The unstable orbits and the size of ℓ_1 .* Table 5 lists unstable periodic orbits computed between $J = 8.5$ and 9.75 . Near a Hopf point the normal form predicts that $(\text{peak-to-peak } u)^2 \approx 16|q_u|^2 \operatorname{Re} \lambda'(J_{H1})(J_{H1} - J)/(\omega_1 \ell_1)$, with q normalized as in (3); with the proved values of Theorem 2 and $|q_u| \in [0.9999042898, 0.9999042899]$ the factor is $[34.657379, 34.657380]$. The computed ratios decrease towards it as $J \rightarrow J_{H1}$, and a linear extrapolation through the two orbits closest to J_{H1} gives 34.65 (Figure 3(b)). This checks the magnitude of ℓ_1 , not only its sign. The orbits were located at each J separately, by bisecting perturbations of the equilibrium between a return to rest and a spike, the method that located the candidate for Γ_u at $J = 8$; that they and Γ_u belong to the family born at J_{H1} is suggested by the decreasing amplitudes, not proved. At J_{H2} no periodic orbits were computed; the supercriticality there rests on Theorem 2(e) alone.
- *High-precision values at $J = 8$, $E_l = 10.613$.* Newton’s method on midpoints gives

$$T_s \approx 16.00771280383757999237802\dots, \quad \mu_1(\Gamma_s) \approx 0.07089678069271872876\dots,$$

Table 5: Numerical: the unstable periodic orbits between $J = 8.5$ and J_{H1} at $E_l = 10.613$ (stage 2 of `data/certify_bistability.txt`), and the ratio of Figure 3(b), whose predicted limit is $[34.657379, 34.657380]$.

J	period (ms)	peak-to-peak u (mV)	$J_{H1} - J$	ratio
8.50	12.6126	8.1128	1.2754	51.60
9.00	11.6921	5.7233	0.7754	42.24
9.50	11.0248	3.1849	0.2754	36.83
9.70	10.7986	1.6298	0.0754	35.21
9.75	10.7448	0.9414	0.0254	34.84

$$T_u \approx 14.34360094817270692874908\dots,$$

and the multipliers $10.3028828212211696095\dots$ and $0.19683222913631744833\dots$ of Γ_u , inside the enclosures of Tables 1 and 2. They are the starting points of Figure 2.

9 Reproducibility

The programs need Python 3.11 with the packages of `code/requirements.txt` (python-flint 0.9.0, mpmath, SymPy, numpy, SciPy; matplotlib for the figures). From the folder of this paper:

command	what it proves, and time
<code>python3 code/certify_equilibria_hopf.py</code>	Proposition 2.3, Theorems 1, 2; 38 checks; about 13 s
<code>python3 code/certify_bistability.py</code>	Theorems 4, 5, Corollary 6; 84 checks; 40.7 min on four cores, of which stage 4b took 1624 s with four worker processes
<code>python3 code/make_numbers.py</code>	the numbers and tables of this paper, from <code>data/</code>
<code>python3 code/make_figures.py</code>	the figures, about 10 s

`code/certify_bistability.py` accepts `--no-ball` (skip stage 4b, and so Theorem 4) and `--quick` (skip the mpmath tests and stage 6); stage 4b uses four worker processes, a number fixed in `code/ball_stable.py`. Its program Theorems A, B and C are, here, part of Corollary 6, Theorem 5 and Theorem 4. The summary of `data/certify_bistability.txt` cites the 27 checks of an earlier version of `code/certify_equilibria_hopf.py`; the present version runs the same 27 and adds the tests of (3), two controls, the independent enclosure of E_l^* , the check $J_{H1} > 8$ and the ledger of printed bounds.

Runs. `code/certify_equilibria_hopf.py` was rerun for this paper on 2026-09-27, on a machine shared with other jobs: all 38 checks passed. `data/certify_bistability.txt` is the output committed on 2026-09-26 together with the present version of the programs it runs; it was not rerun in full for this paper. All its stages except 4b were rerun for this paper (`--no-ball`, one process): on 2026-09-27 it passed all 82 of its checks (28 proof checks, 24 negative controls, 23 self-tests and 7 numerical-only checks; the 2 proof checks of stage 4b were not run), and each of its 318 lines other than run times is identical to a line of the committed output, except the 4 that differ because stage 4b was skipped (it printed and re-read 144 bounds instead of 333, and its summary states the bistability at the three values only). Its output is `data/certify_bistability_no_ball_2026-09-27.txt`. The files of the proofs have the following SHA-256 prefixes:

file	SHA-256, first 16 digits
code/certify_equilibria_hopf.py	c90b6b855a1d023f
code/hh_ball.py	754623075e174f8d
code/certify_bistability.py	d86259449f19c2c2
code/hh_arb.py	88321fe660c541fd
code/hh_lohner.py	c358d2e56d5d2544
code/certlib.py	6311f7f18086f2e6
code/ball_stable.py	b537177ea9f901de
code/outward.py	417e163289459752
code/tests_integrator.py	6e8417d0b6bff303
code/testsys.py	bbb47b4132b0164e
data/certify_equilibria_hopf.txt	7d9ae4980a3d69e1
data/certify_bistability.txt	ef41ffbd34b4e7d9

10 Limitations and what has been checked

What is not proved. The Hopf statements (Corollary 3) are local and give no size of the neighbourhoods. The periodic orbits are proved only at $J = 8$ and the currents equivalent to it; the saddle-type orbit only at three values of E_l , because the C^1 enclosures over boxes of the size the E_l interval requires are too wide for it. Uniqueness of the orbits holds only within their boxes. Nothing is proved about other attractors, the basins, the separatrix, the fold of cycles or the global organization of the periodic orbits (Remark 3.1), or the equilibria for $J > 200$.

Sources. Theorem 4.5 and formula (3) are used as stated in Kuznetsov’s encyclopedia article [22], read for this paper; we have not checked them against his book [21], which the article cites. The formula is tested on systems with independently known ℓ_1 (Section 4) and its magnitude is consistent with the numerics (Section 8). Rump’s Theorem 13.3 [27] was read in an earlier study of this project; Gershgorin’s paper [10] was not read, and Lemma 5.10 is proved here. Of the literature on the model we read in full [30, 12]; in part [17] (the equations and Table 3), [29, 16, 11, 13, 8, 9, 24]; abstracts or reviews of [28, 2, 14, 7]; and not [15, 26]. In particular we have not read Du and Hassard [7] beyond its first page, Hassard [15], Rinzel and Miller [26], or pages 939–952 of Guckenheimer and Labouriau [11], and the arXiv and PubMed searches of 2026-09-27 could not be run (the services refused queries that day), so the statements of priority in Section 1 are limited to the searches of 2026-09-25 to 2026-09-27 that did run. Whether the criticality of the two Hopf points has been proved before is not settled: Du and Hassard may contain it.

What has been checked. The checks of this work were made within the project, by separate AI agent sessions. The model of both programs was compared with the 1952 equations, and `code/certify_bistability.py` had the mutation reading described in Section 7; its fixes have not been read again. An inventory of the results, a review of the prior articles and an outline preceded this manuscript. The written proofs of this paper have not had a second reading. No one outside the project has reviewed this work.

11 Future work

Guckenheimer and Oliva’s chaotic dynamics near $J = 7.86$ [12] is the natural next target. Our numerical study (in the folder of this paper, `work/chaos/`, not part of this manuscript) relocates their periodic points as fixed points of the return map to $u = 4.5$ crossed with u increasing, and finds two h-sets around two orbits of the branch born at J_{H1} whose covering relations hold in dense

sampling, avoiding the multiplier of order 10^7 of one of their orbits; a proof would need of the order of 10^3 to 10^4 box integrations with the C^1 method of Section 5. Other open steps are a proof of the fold of cycles, which would bound the bistable range from below, the saddle-type orbit over the whole E_l interval, and statements about the boundary between the basins. The propagated action potential of the Hodgkin–Huxley cable equation at the 1952 constants is a separate problem, for which the literature we reached has proofs only for modified systems.

Data availability. The programs of this paper and their outputs are in its folder: `code/`, `data/`, and the scripts that write the numbers, tables and figures of the manuscript. A public release of that folder with an archived DOI is planned before submission.

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